Between Adoption and Governance: How AI Systems Are Translated in a Plural Public Organization

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Abstract

This thesis investigates how Region Uppsala, a Swedish regional public sector organization, translates governance templates for Artificial Intelligence (AI) in an environment characterized by institutional pluralism. Through an exploratory qualitative embedded case study design, twelve in-depth interviews were conducted across three analytical units within the organization: the administrative AI (Microsoft 365 Copilot); the clinical AI at Akademiska Sjukhuset, and the pre-adoption AI in welfare and an AI specialized unit. Translation theory and institutional logics provide the analytical framework.

The study shows how the translation outcomes vary systematically between the units. Three contextual conditions were abductively identified as an explanation for this variation: risk proximity, logic dominance and governance ownership. Where proximity to risk was low and governance unassigned, the result was a ceremonial stabilization of the template. In the clinical unit, where the risk proximity was highest, the dominant professional logic led to a negotiated stabilization of the template through a process of layering. Finally, when the governance of AI use was designed as a prospective, based on a bureaucratic-legal logic of AI governance, an anticipatory compliance was adopted to the template before any specific system had been deployed. The responsibility gap observed across all three sites is therefore not simply a failure of implementation, it is a gap that has been produced structurally.

Keywords: *Institutional pluralism, translation theory, AI governance, public sector, institutionalization, triad, Sweden, accountability, qualitative case study*

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Abbreviations

AI = Artificial Intelligence

CDO = Chief Digital Officer

EU = European Union

GDPR = General Data Protection Regulation

GO = Governance Ownership

IND = Inductive code (QualCoder prefix)

ISO = International Organization for Standardization

KPI = Key Performance Indicator

LD = Logic Dominance

LLM = Large Language Model

NS = Node Set (analytical coding category, NS1-NS5)

P = Participant (e.g. P1, P2)

RP = Risk Proximity

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1. Introduction

1.1. The Institutional Context of European Public Sector AI

European public sector organizations operate within a dense context characterized by multiple and partially competing demands (Fredriksson & Pallas, 2016), in which expectations of legality, professionalism, efficiency, transparency, and democratic accountability, coexist and affect organizational action (e.g., Meyer & Rowan, 1977). According to DiMaggio and Powell (1983), coercive, normative, and mimetic pressures at a field-level lead to similarities among organizations. However, in the public administration context, the pressures do not lead to isomorphism. Instead, the organizations remain embedded in an enduring institutional pluralism, where multiple institutional logics coexist rather than converge (Reay & Hinings, 2009; Jarzabkowski et al., 2009).

Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools, such as those for generative productivity support and clinical decision-making, are introduced into this plural setting as part of a larger digital governance initiative (Mergel et al., 2019; Hinings et al., 2018). At the European level, the digitalization discourse frames AI to achieve efficiency, coherence, and performance optimization in public services (Hinings et al., 2018). Simultaneously, the EU AI Act expresses expectations of explainability, accountability, and risk management, which institutionalizes specific governance standards at the field level (Laux et al., 2024). Since the regulatory framework is in the process of being enacted in the EU member states, public organizations currently interpret these governance expectations in a tentative and developing way (European Commission, 2024). This study therefore approaches the EU AI Act as a discursive resource, and a governance model used by actors to claim legitimacy or account for organizational choices, rather than a governance template already in force. The analytic distinction between discursive resource and regulatory instrument is sustained throughout, and actors' references to the Act are interpreted as evidence of theorization rather than compliance.

AI enters both as a technology and governance template embedded in a discourse of regulation, auditing, and transparency (Power, 1997; Giest & Grimmelikhuijsen, 2020). AI systems, often

portrayed as objective decision support instruments, may influence authority relations and professional practices. AI tools can codify evaluation criteria, produce performance data, and establish decision-making routines that reinforce managerial power and reconfigure professional autonomy (Margetts & Dunleavy, 2013; Lammi, 2021). Previous empirical research conducted in Swedish public agencies shows that AI tools, whether applied in a clinical context, an administrative process, or a social welfare decision-making process, may force professionals to adjust their assessments to the output of the automated system, which decreases the space for interpretation and shifts accountability (Berman et al., 2024; Selten & Klievink, 2024; Lammi, 2021). In this way, AI governance is not merely a question of technological renewal; it is a governance moment when authority, accountability, and legitimacy are reconfigured in an already institutionally plural setting.

However, AI in public organizations is a multifaceted phenomenon (Petersson et al., 2022; Yuan & Chen, 2025). It includes everything from generative productivity tools that affect administrative practices to algorithmic tools that influence clinical or operational decisions directly. The degree to which AI triggers institutional tensions depend greatly on where in the organization an AI system is positioned and whose authority it affects (Selten & Klievink, 2024). In this study, institutionalization refers to the outcome of translation processes through which a governance template becomes stabilized, routinized, and taken for granted as legitimate in organizational structures and practices (Tolbert & Zucker, 1996; Sahlin & Wedlin, 2008). Institutionalization does not imply full agreement or uniform use, but rather that the translated idea has gained enough legitimacy and durability to influence decision-making over time and has become embedded in artifacts, routines, and relational systems that carry its organizational meaning (Pallas et al., 2016; Berger & Luckmann, 1967). There is a lack of systematic knowledge about how professional autonomy, bureaucratic accountability, managerial control, and political legitimacy are negotiated in processes where algorithmic systems are introduced.

1.2. AI Translation Beyond Diffusion

A large part of the extant literature treats AI implementation in terms of adoption, compliance, or diffusion implicitly assuming that governance models are transferred from the policy level to the

organizational level with minor adaptations (Selten & Klievink, 2024). In contrast, Scandinavian institutionalism focuses on translation: the active editing, modifying, and recontextualizing of ideas as they move across organizational settings (Czarniawska & Joerges, 1996; Sahlin & Wedlin, 2008). Rather than being transferred intact, governance templates are edited to fit local identities, power structures, and institutional arrangements.

Viewing AI as a governance template subject to translation shifts the analytical focus from whether AI complies with governance requirements to how it is edited, modified, fitted into, or decoupled from existing institutional arrangements. Such translation processes may involve reframing AI to protect professional legitimacy, layering control mechanisms to address accountability concerns, or decoupling when adopting AI formally while leaving core practices intact, it is not always by choice, sometimes due to the algorithmic opacity the decoupling could be structural (Meyer & Rowan, 1977). These editing dynamics are particularly consequential in the current moment: since the EU AI Act has not yet been fully enacted, the uncertainty over what the template exactly prescribes may itself facilitate processes of editing and decoupling. Furthermore, these editing processes are complicated by institutional plurality: where multiple logics coexist, contest, and dominate, AI adoption activates tensions between them simultaneously. Chapter 2 develops this argument in full.

Swedish regional public agencies provide a relevant empirical context for this study. These agencies operate under a constitutionally embedded mandate for healthcare, welfare, and regional development (SFS 2017:725) and are simultaneously subject to professional, bureaucratic-legal, managerial, and political logics which make them structurally suited to studying how AI governance templates are translated under conditions of institutional pluralism (Fredriksson & Pallas, 2016). They also operate within the EU AI Act framework, which sets field-level expectations for explainability, accountability, and risk management (Laux et al., 2024). This setting is characterized by a nested complexity of logics built on top of one another (Cooper et al., 1996; Jarzabkowski et al., 2009), making translation processes both necessary and observable. The empirical context and case selection are further discussed in Chapter 3.

1.3. Research Gap

A systematic research gap exists despite that the governance of AI has received increasing research attention in recent years, few empirical studies have examined how multiple institutional logics influence the local implementation of AI systems in public organizations (Petersson et al., 2022; Selten & Klievink, 2024; Wirtz et al., 2018). Most of the research in the field has focused on the regulatory frameworks (Berman et al., 2024; Selten & Klievink, 2024; Söderlund, 2025), ethical guidelines (Berman et al., 2024; Selten & Klievink, 2024), and national and EU-level policy initiatives for the use of AI (Berman et al., 2024; Selten & Klievink, 2024; Söderlund, 2025). As a result, there is limited research on how AI systems are perceived, negotiated, and practiced within organizational contexts where multiple institutional logics are present (Berman et al., 2024; Selten & Klievink, 2024). Specifically, there is a lack of systematic knowledge about how professional autonomy, bureaucratic accountability, managerial control, and political legitimacy are negotiated in processes where algorithmic systems are introduced (Berman et al., 2024; Lammi, 2021; Petersson et al., 2022; Selten & Klievink, 2024; Yuan & Chen, 2025). This knowledge gap is evident regardless of the regulatory context; even in situations where governance requirements are clearly defined, there is still a need for empirical research on how AI systems locally gain or fail to bring legitimacy in the presence of multiple institutional logics. The EU AI Act and its governance requirements further emphasize this knowledge gap (Laux et al., 2024); however, the need for empirical research on the translation of logics predates the EU AI Act and is independent of it.

1.4. Research Aim and Questions

This study addresses the outlined knowledge gap by studying the translation and institutionalization of AI-based systems in Region Uppsala, a Swedish regional public agency. The multiple institutional logics present in Region Uppsala and its advanced AI agenda make it a theoretically informed case for this study.

This study employs a qualitative embedded case study design (Yin, 2018). It uses semi-structured interviews with key organizational actors in Region Uppsala. The choice of research strategy and methods is further elaborated upon in Chapter 3.

The purpose of this study is not to examine the technical performance of algorithms, citizen's trust in AI systems, or societal opinions about AI in general. Instead, the purpose is to study how AI governance templates are translated and stabilized within regional public organizations, with a particular focus on how actors make sense of AI systems and how such sense-making informs translation processes under conditions of institutional pluralism. The empirical setting is a single regional agency in Sweden, and the contributions are theoretical rather than statistical in nature. The thesis is bounded by the following overarching research question:

How are AI-based systems translated and institutionalized within a Swedish regional public agency under conditions of institutional pluralism?

In addressing this research question, the study is guided by two sub-questions:

1. *How do actors perceive and navigate competing institutional logics in the implementation of AI systems?*
2. *What forms of translation, such as reframing, layering, or decoupling, can be identified in the institutionalization of AI systems?*

The two sub-questions are thus analytically connected, as perceptions of and responses to competing logics (Sub-question 1) will inform how actors construct their translations (Sub-question 2). This study does not only seek to determine which translation mechanisms are present, but also why there is such variation across different AI systems, organizational areas and actor roles. It is this explanatory interest that distinguishes the present study from descriptive studies of AI governance and further reflects the abductive research strategy introduced in chapter 3. For instance, perceived tensions between professional and managerial logics might lead to different translation strategies (e.g. layering, reframing, or decoupling). In this sense, the mechanisms of translation are not only responses to technical adaptations, but also institutional responses influenced by actor interpretations of the institutional tensions between competing logics.

1.5. The study's Contributions

The main argument in this study is that AI governance is not a technocratic initiative but a translation process, where meaning, legitimacy, and authority are contested and constructed through the institutional logics. The study contributes to the literature in four ways. First, it contributes to the institutional logics literature by identifying three concepts (risk proximity (RP), logic dominance (LD), and governance ownership (GO)) as a triad of conditions that together enable a plausible explanation for the variance of translation dynamics across domains, that is, of why the same pluralistic environment would yield such different patterns of translation in different domains. Second, it challenges diffusion theory by showing that the same template for governance can act simultaneously as a compliance standard of practice and as a rationalized myth, in different units of the same organization. Third, the study contributes to the translation literature proposing the fourth mechanism of translation theory ''opacity-driven translation breakdown'' which relates to the algorithmic objects that actors cannot consciously translate or edit due to the opacity of the object. Fourth, it adds to the institutionalization model by identifying de-institutionalization without sedimented learning, as an outcome of the institutionalization process.

The following chapter maps the theoretical framework that guides this study, followed by chapter three to present the methods and the case selection. Chapter four showcases the empirical analysis of three analytical units. Chapter five discusses the findings against theoretical framework and finally chapter six presents the conclusion.

2. Theoretical Background

This chapter develops the theoretical framework that will guide the analysis of AI-based systems in a Swedish regional public agency. With a point of departure in institutional theory and Scandinavian institutionalism, the chapter conceptualizes AI governance as a traveling governance template that is interpreted, translated, and stabilized in organizational contexts marked by institutional pluralism. The chapter begins with an outline of the concept of institutional pluralism and the role of competing institutional logics in public organizations. It then introduces translation theory as a framework for analyzing how governance templates are adapted and enacted in local contexts. Finally, it discusses institutionalization as the stabilization of translated practices and presents the analytical framework that will be used in the empirical analysis.

2.1. Institutional Pluralism in Public Organizations

Institutional environments comprise socially constructed belief systems about what organizations ought to do and the legitimate means to do it (Meyer & Rowan, 1977). Institutions aren't hard-and-fast external constraints but objectivated patterns of meaning (Berger & Luckmann, 1967) that arise from routinized interaction and are taken for granted as the way to do things. The first wave of neo-institutional research focused on the homogenization of organizations within a field to secure legitimacy in conformance with dominant institutional prescriptions (DiMaggio & Powell, 1983). However, it is rare to find fields characterized by single coherent logics. More recent research has recognized that organizations are commonly faced with conditions of institutional pluralism (Reay & Hinings, 2009). Belief systems define appropriate organizational behavior, legitimate authority, and credible knowledge (Meyer & Rowan, 1977).

Institutional pluralism implies the presence of multiple normative orders in the same organizational field that prescribe somewhat conflicting standards for evaluating appropriate behavior (Greenwood et al., 2011). This is a structural condition more than environmental complexity, in which organizations face ongoing, relatively enduring tensions between different principles of evaluation (Greenwood et al., 2011). What is valued by one normative order may be considered inappropriate by another.

In this sense, pluralism implies that legitimacy is not singular (Kraatz & Block, 2008). The public sector is a context particularly dominated by pluralism (Fredriksson & Pallas, 2016). Public sector organizations operate simultaneously in a legal environment of legally enforceable regulations, a professional environment of professional discretion and expertise, a performance-based environment of performance measurement and improvement, and a democratic environment of political accountability (Fredriksson & Pallas, 2016).

In the Scandinavian institutionalist approach, templates of governance are conceptualized as ideas traveling from one place to another and being selectively interpreted and translated along the way (Sahlin & Wedlin, 2008). Their reception is thus influenced by the institutional context into which they are inserted, in this study, the plural configuration of regional governance in Sweden outlined above. The following section details how the four institutional logics construct these claims to legitimacy prior to exploring translation theory.

2.2. Institutional Logics and Legitimacy Conflicts

The four logics identified by Fredriksson and Pallas (2016) building on Thornton et al. (2012) for Swedish regional public agencies are summarized in Table 1, together with the specific tensions each logic generates when AI systems are introduced.

Table 1

Institutional Logics, Core Principles, and AI Tensions

Logic	Core principle	Basis for legitimate decisions	AI tension
Professional	Expertise, autonomy, judgement based on discretion	Evidence-based cases assessment; professional norms over standardized procedures (Fredriksson & Pallas, 2016)	Codified algorithm could limit professional discretion; recommendations may override expert judgement (Berman et al., 2024)

Logic	Core principle	Basis for legitimate decisions	AI tension
Bureaucratic-legal	Accountability frameworks, rule-following	Documented compliance with codified rules; transparent, auditable decisions (Fredriksson & Pallas, 2016)	Opacity of AI creates a responsibility gap means unclear who is accountable for algorithmic decisions (Laux et al., 2024; Yuan & Chen, 2025)
Managerial	Efficiency, performance measurement, resource optimization	Measurable outcomes and KPIs; data-driven consistency (Margetts & Dunleavy, 2013)	AI formalizes managerial control over professional domains; may enforce efficiency over discretion (Lammi, 2021)
Political	Democratic legitimacy, fairness, responsiveness	Decisions are justified by societal values; accountability to elected individuals(Fredriksson & Pallas, 2016)	Automated decisions reduce visible political accountability; opacity limits democratic oversight Laux et al. (2024)

Note. Logics are derived from Fredriksson and Pallas (2016). AI tensions are obtained from the empirical literature cited and from the cross-unit analysis in Chapter 4. Analytically logics are distinct but co-exist in practice and are not mutually exclusive.

All four logics are present in Swedish regional agencies and are not mutually exclusive over time. However, they are not necessarily equal. There is a general tendency towards expansion of the managerial logic in the public sector as performance governance and efficiency become increasingly important in areas previously dominated by professional or bureaucratic-legal logic, which is the so-called "managerialization" of the public sector (Fredriksson & Pallas, 2016; Margetts & Dunleavy, 2013). Therefore, the analytical framework does not assume a plural equilibrium but is open to exploring power asymmetries between the logics, not only which logics are present, but which logic dominates the decision to adopt, and which logics create resistance. Consequently, organizational actors face many situations in which the different logics promote diverging views on appropriate behavior. For example, decisions based on professional

knowledge can be deemed appropriate according to the professional logic but inappropriate according to the managerial logic if they are not possible to evaluate in terms of performance. Efficiency reforms advocated by the managerial logic can, on the other hand, collide with the bureaucratic logic's emphasis on legal security and transparency (Fredriksson & Pallas, 2016).

In the existing organizational arrangement, AI causes latent tensions between the previously mentioned four competing logics. Therefore, the organizational actors must interpret how these algorithmic technologies relate to their established normative expectations and authority structures. Hence, institutional logics help to explain these conflicts when governance template such as AI enters pluralistic public organizations.

In the following section this study builds on this view by scrutinizing how these tensions are addressed through the lens of translation, in which governance templates are edited, adopted and reframed within specific organizational environments.

2.3. Translation as an Organizational Process

The institutional literature has long argued that reforms are not transported between organizations in an intact form but are translated and edited as they diffuse between contexts (Czarniawska & Joerges, 1996; Sahlin & Wedlin, 2008). As AI governance templates are translated into organizations, they encounter prevailing norms, power structures and institutional arrangements that influence how they are perceived and understood (Sahlin & Wedlin, 2008). Governance templates may also function as rationalized myths (Meyer & Rowan, 1977), ideas understood to be modern and necessary even before their effects are known. In such instances, translation is geared towards legitimacy rather than use, leading to decoupling rather than institutionalization. The empirical analysis therefore differentiated between translation that indexes embedding and translation that indexes decoupling.

Translation is a process influenced by context, and translators within the institutionalized system of value from professional to managerial or legal shape what is considered a legitimate solution to an organizational problem (Pallas et al., 2016). Therefore, AI systems can be fundamentally translated and understood differently based on which dominant logic frame it.

Translation theory identifies several editing mechanisms that describe how reform ideas are translated to fit the local institutional context. Three of them are of particular relevance for understanding how AI- systems are translated in public organizations:

First, *reframing* refers to the re-interpretation of a reform to fit with dominant institutional expectations. Actors may highlight certain dimensions of a reform while muting others to make it fit with existing norms and practices. For example, algorithmic decision-support systems are often framed as decision aids rather than substitutes for professional judgement. Empirical research on the implementation of AI in public organizations shows that such framing is important for maintaining professional legitimacy while introducing algorithmic tools in decision processes (Berman et al., 2024; Selten & Klievink, 2024).

Second, *layering* refers to the creation of new structures or procedures that enable a reform to exist alongside dominant institutional arrangements rather than replacing them. Instead of displacing established routines, new practices are created that enable the new technology to co-exist with prevailing accountability requirements. Such arrangements are reminiscent of what Söderlund (2025) labels as qualified transparency, where access to scrutinize algorithmic systems is granted to specialized actors to preserve legal accountability. In this sense, layering can be understood as a defensive strategy that permits organizations to address legal and accountability concerns raised by algorithmic opacity.

Sahlin and Wedlin (2008) have noted that decoupling the ceremonial adoption of ideas without operational penetration is a recurring observed pattern within the circulation of ideas, even as their own research extends beyond it to show that circulating ideas can also produce substantive change. Therefore, decoupling sits at the intersection of the two traditions and is treated here as a third translation mechanism.

Decoupling refers to instances when organizations adopt reforms at a formal level but limit their penetration into ongoing practices (Meyer & Rowan, 1977). In such a case, reforms serve mainly a ceremonial purpose by conveying an image of conformity to external constituents and have limited impact on core practices. This is what the framework conceptualizes as ceremonial stabilization: the organization formally adopts a governance template but decouples from it in practice. Empirical research on algorithmic decision-support systems suggests that such decoupling may happen when professionals are allowed to override algorithmic

recommendations that contradicts contextual judgement or professional expertise (Berman et al., 2024). However, translation is often a politicized process (Pallas et al., 2016). Organizational actors may not have an equal say in how a reform is interpreted and enacted. Line managers, legal officers, and IT officers may all attempt to influence how new technologies are translated into organizational practices. Translation, therefore, may involve a power game over who gets to be the (chief) "editor" of a reform and whose translation wins out in constituting its organizational meaning. Importantly, translation is not always a voluntary or negotiated process when dominant actors force a particular translation over their subordinate actors. Therefore, coercive nature of translation is relevant for this study as it affects the type of stabilization observed. What may appear to be negotiated stabilization at the organizational level might be coerced compliance at the individual practitioner level. These translation mechanisms are one lens to view AI's enactment as an organizational activity. One theoretical limitation with these translations is that they all concern the enactment of ideas as text; they assume the ideas enacted exist for a translator to read, reflect on, and edit, and they assume that an actor can make such a translation. This study is explicitly aware of this limitation and considers it a question to be investigated empirically rather than assumed to be a given: the question of the extent to which the opacity of algorithms constrains the kind of enactment the above framework prescribes.

This explains how reform ideas were edited but does not explain why such plural contexts lead to different editing dynamics in different sites within the same organization. The next section will specify the three conditions that explains the variation.

2.4. Translation Conditions: Risk Proximity (RP), Logic Dominance (LD), and Governance Ownership (GO)

The three conditions elaborated in this section were abductively refined against the empirical material, refer to section 3.5 for the description of how it has been carried out. They are presented here, therefore, theoretically in order to aid analysis but are emergent rather than pre-determined. In the previous section we found that AI governance templates are not taken into organizations in their original form, but translated in practices like reframing, layering and decoupling, and translation is not always a voluntary or symmetrical process. What translation theory in its classical Scandinavian formulation is not as clear about, however, is the question:

Why does a single plural context lead to different translation dynamics in different sites and objects of reform? In a similar vein, Reay and Hinings (2009) suggest that the competition between the logics is not always settled in abstract; it is settled situationally, in the context of specific practices, locations, and accountability arrangements.

Based on this notion, this section identifies the three conditions under which translation is being practiced in public organizations when using AI: risk proximity, which highlights how close the technology is from citizens, patients or any subjects of rights , LD is about the logic that weighs more heavily in comparison to other logics where AI is deployed and governance ownership relates to the position and clear accountability for the deployed technology. These conditions are analytical specifications that explain how AI governance, institutional pluralism and translation literature together they shape the translation process in different organizational settings.

2.4.1. Risk proximity (RP)

RP is defined as how near an AI application is to consequential decisions about a citizen, patient, or rights-bearing subject. This distinction has been institutionalized at a regulatory level by the European AI Act (European Commission, 2024), which categorizes AI systems into prohibited, high-risk, limited-risk and minimal-risk classes with an escalating range of obligations applied to systems that have the potential to impact health, safety or fundamental rights (Laux et al., 2024). However, the concept is not only legal, but also institutional. In a systematic review on accountability of AI in the public sector, Yuan and Chen (2025) note that accountability claims on an AI system strengthen as its outputs become more closely linked with professional decisions, which may have consequential effects. This pattern is also found by (Berman et al., 2024), whose findings on the AI systems in Swedish public sector are that those with outputs in casework are subject to considerably more demands for transparency and oversight than their outputs in indirect or advisory capacities. RP thus affects translation by raising the institutional stakes of translation. An AI system that sits close to a consequential decision is likely to trigger more intensive instances of reframing, layering and decoupling than if it were far removed from consequentiality because the former is responding to a higher-pressure accountability environment.

2.4.2. Logic dominance (LD)

The institutional logics presented in Section 2.2 do not exist in balance in every site of a public organization. According to Reay and Hinings (2009), even in an organizational space where multiple logics have been co-present over a long period of time, a single logic tends to be dominant in a given site of practice in that a dominant logic offers the vocabulary actors tend to draw from to evaluate decisions, authorize power and to identify legitimate forms of knowledge. An equivalent argument has been made for Swedish regional public agencies by Fredriksson and Pallas (2016) with their acknowledgement of a general increase in managerial logic alongside an observation that this has a dominant logic that differs for each activity. Their findings include professional care is underpinned by the professional logic, casework by the bureaucratic-legal logic and digitalization efforts by the managerial logic. LD affects translation because it offers the logic by which the dominant system offers to make room for the plural systems. An AI system that is an easy fit to the dominant logic of a site is more readily reframed in its translation than an AI system that does not fit and is more likely to be layered or decoupled. This echoes the point made by Pallas et al. (2016) with their argument that the idea of a reform may be translated differently depending on the different institutionalized system of values into which it is inserted.

2.4.3. Governance ownership (GO)

GO relates to the location within an organization to which the responsibility of an AI system rests and how explicit this is made. Selten and Klievink (2024) argue that a choice for public organizations in adopting AI systems is between separation, i.e., AI governance is concentrated and located in a unit that is separate or not closely connected from operational practice, and integration, where governance is distributed across the line organization closer to operation. This argument mirrors Hinings et al. (2018) with their acknowledgement that the institutional impact of a digital innovation depends on where the ownership of the new arrangement is assigned, if it is contested or remains unspoken. The logic of translation is governed by the owning editor. If the responsibility of translation is located, the translation of the AI system can be expected to align with the logic of this site. However, if responsibility is spread out, for example, between a central digital function, a dedicated AI unit, line management and the operational professionals, there is no clear editor of translation and it is possible for the same AI system to be translated in

the same time but in different ways in different parts of the organization. The literature on accountability (Bovens, 2007; Yuan & Chen, 2025) also provides reasons for the importance of this. With unclear ownership, where an AI system already tends to open gaps in accountability, the likelihood of a ceremonial translation increase.

2.4.4. How the three conditions combine

The three conditions do not exist in a vacuum. They combine to produce different dynamics for translation, the combinations of which roughly correspond to the three types of modes of stabilization discussed in the following section. When all three conditions exist at low levels, there is insufficient institutional support for translation and ceremonial stabilization is the preferred outcome. When two of the three conditions, RP and LD, have a higher level, the role of translation becomes one of defensive editing, where layering is utilized in defense of a dominant logic against the new system. In such situations, ownership of the new system may be explicitly clear, but the responsibility of translation remains contested. When ownership resides with a dedicated unit and RP has not yet come into being but will do so at some point in the future, the process of translation is forward-looking and anticipates future governance arrangements rather than the existing reality. Thus, this model considers the translation as a process and, the three conditions are situational variables that explain why the same context produces different translation dynamics and modes of stabilization as outcome. This conceptual model informs the selection of the case studies and how the translation process in the case studies are read comparatively in Chapter 4.

2.5. Institutionalization as Stabilization

After outlining the three conditions defined in section 2.4 shape the unfolding of a translation, its ultimate institutional trajectory is determined through a process of stabilization. The term institutionalization refers to the long-running process by which a given practice becomes habitualized over time and becomes taken for granted (Berger & Luckmann, 1967; Tolbert & Zucker, 1996). Tolbert and Zucker (1996) model institutionalization as a three-stage process that

consists of *habitualization, objectification*, and *sedimentation*. Habitualization describes how new practices are repeated as a practical solution to an organizational problem. Objectification is the process through which such practices become collectively defined as an appropriate and legitimate solution to the problem. Finally, sedimentation denotes the long-term routinization of a practice across time, in which the practice endures even beyond the actors who created it and becomes embedded in the organizational structure. Once practices reach the stage of sedimentation, they no longer need active justification to ensure their continued existence because their legitimacy is taken for granted.

In public organizations that are characterized by institutional pluralism, however, institutionalization rarely means full displacement of old practices. New practices instead typically become routinized through the layered mode of institutional logics in which a new logic becomes layered on top of a pre-existing logic and thereby co-exists with an extant structure or norm (Jarzabkowski et al., 2009). In such a context, organizational change tends to occur through a gradual layering of practices rather than a punctuated replacement of one practice with another. New governance practices thus typically sediment on top of an older set of governance practices rather than supplant it.

In translation terms, institutionalization is the anchoring of translated objects of ideas into the structures and practices of organizations (Sahlin & Wedlin, 2008). As the templates for organizing governance travel across organizations, they are edited and modified by actors in the local contexts to make them fit with institutionalized ideas in the local context. When such translated structures are established in the routines, processes and governance structures, the edited version of the idea becomes institutionalized. The institutionalization implies not that the original model for reform is sustained, but that its translated version is (Sahlin & Wedlin, 2008).

The institutionalization of structures takes place through specific carriers of the organization. Institutionalized logics and governance practices are carried by artefacts, routines, symbolic systems, and relational systems that reproduce the institutionalized meanings and practices over time (Pallas et al., 2016). In the case of AI decision-support systems, these carriers could be the artefact itself, formal decision processes incorporating the algorithmic output, symbolic systems

about digital modernization, and relational systems between managers, legal officers, and professionals. The institutionalization does not only depend on the adoption of an innovation, but also on how these carriers sustain the innovation in the daily work of the organization.

Under institutional pluralism, stabilization should be understood as a temporary rather than permanent settlement of competing logics (Reay & Hinings, 2009). Three modes of stabilization are analytically possible depending on how actors negotiate competing legitimacy claims; these are summarized in Table 2.

Table 2

Three Modes of Institutional Stabilization Under Pluralism

Stabilization mode	**What it looks like**	**Producing conditions**
Substantive embedding	When AI is embedded in daily decision-making routines; it may develop into sedimentation where practices become taken for granted beyond the actors who introduced them (Tolbert & Zucker, 1996)	Strong logic alignment; clear governance ownership; high risk proximity will most likely activate accountability norms
Negotiated stabilization	When AI is in active use, but its authority, domain, and governance remain contested across competing logics; they neither fully embedded nor decoupled (Reay & Hinings, 2009)	Competing logics of near equal institutional strength; partial governance ownership
Ceremonial stabilization	Formal adoption of AI with loose coupling to actual practice; AI is used as a symbol of modernity or compliance but does not change the core work (Meyer & Rowan, 1977)	Low or absent governance ownership; ceremonial adoption to gain legitimacy; managerial logic dominant with absence of bureaucratic-legal anchoring

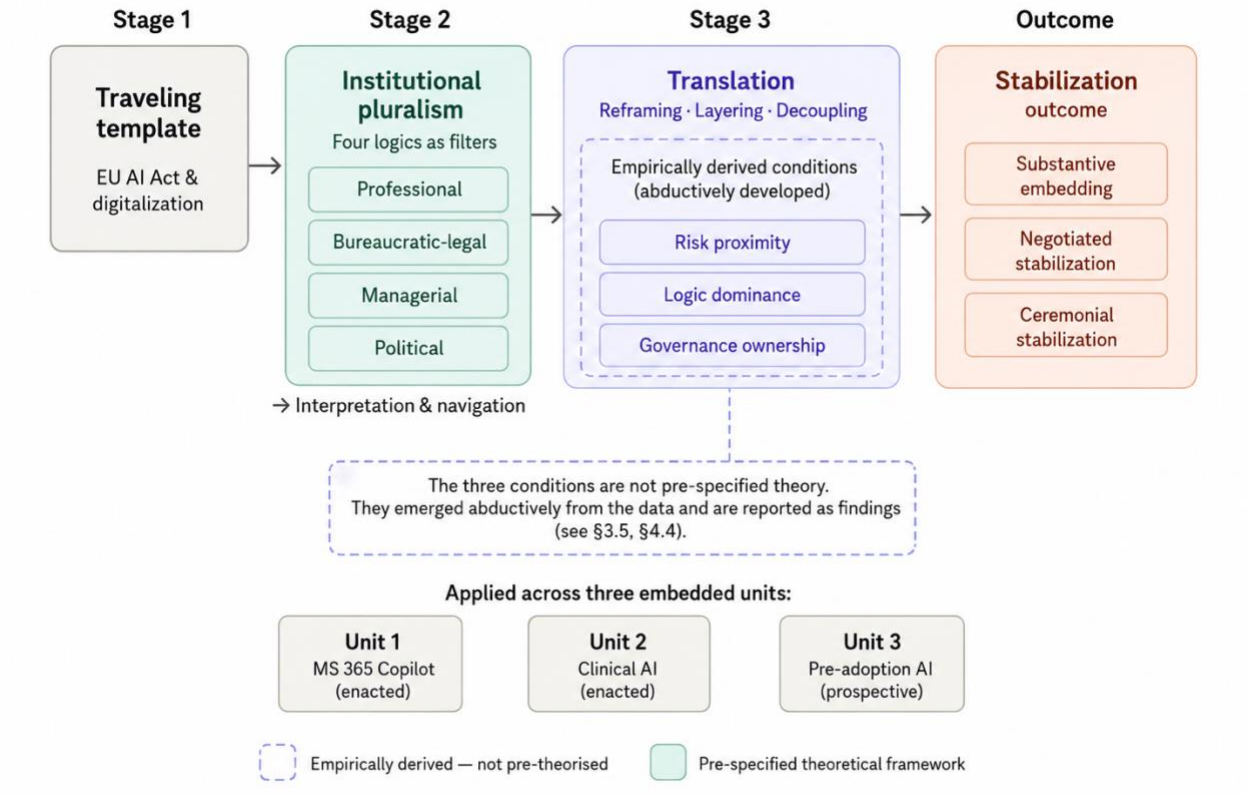
Note. Modes are obtained from Tolbert and Zucker (1996), Reay and Hinings (2009), and Meyer and Rowan (1977). The producing conditions are specified in section 2.4 (risk proximity, logic dominance, governance ownership) and empirical observation in Chapter 4.

This study notes that Tolbert and Zucker's (1996) model is known to be linear progression toward taken-for-grantedness and when talking about institutional pluralism this linearity is questionable since practices that appears sedimented in one logic could be contested under another. As a result, Tolbert and Zucker (1996) model is used here to investigate and trace stabilization not to predict inevitability.

2.6. Analytical framework and Summary

Figure 1

AI Governance as Translation under Institutional Pluralism



Note. The dashed box marks the three conditions resulted from the empirical data. Solid boxes represent pre-specified theoretical framework elements. Figure produced by the author.

This chapter has developed the analytical framework for the study: translation is the main analytical process, stabilization is the outcome it produces, institutional pluralism and logics are the context in which it unfolds, and the triad RP, LD , GO are the conditions that explain variation across sites. Figure 1 synthesizes these elements within the analytical framework guiding this research. The framework moves from left to right. First, a traveling template, specifically, the EU AI Act and the wider AI governance discourse, enters an institutional setting characterized by pluralism. Four logics (professional, bureaucratic-legal, managerial, and political) then filter the template through an interpretive lens (in other words, how actors conceptualize and understand what is happening here). This constitutes the phase of interpretation and navigation. Translation then follows, involving actors' efforts to reconfigure the template via reframing, layering, and decoupling and producing, ultimately, substantive embedding, negotiated stabilization, or ceremonial stabilization, (as described in section 2.5 and table 2).

The dashed box in figure 1 represents the three conditions explaining how different translation dynamics arise in the same plural environment from case to case: that is, RP, LD, and GO. These conditions do not belong to the pre-given framework, they were uncovered abductively from the empirical data and are reported as findings in section 4.4. They are presented here, following their theoretical grounding in section 2.4, for purposes of analytical coherence. Section 3.5 documents the abductive process through which they emerged. The analytical framework is applied here to three embedded units: Microsoft 365 Copilot (Enacted, administrative), clinical AI in Akademiska Sjukhuset (Enacted, clinical), and pre-adoption AI (prospective), section 3.2.3. in the following chapter explains the analysis in detail.

3. Methodology

3.1. Research Design

Qualitative research methods are most appropriate for studying how actors translate, construct meanings and interpret reforms in practice, how they negotiate legitimacy claims and make sense of expectations arising from multiple institutional pressures (Bryman & Bell, 2015; Scott, 2014). In line with this, institutional theory suggests that organizational change occurs through interpretation and sensemaking by actors who are situated within an institutional context, rather than through technical rationality (Scott, 2014). Therefore, qualitative methods are the only means to capture the construction of meaning within an organization in the context of AI systems and how these constructions impact the translation and stabilization of governance template in practice.

Through interview data this study captures how actors construct their organizational reality rather than direct representations of an organizational reality. This approach is aligned with social constructivist ontology which entails that reality is socially constructed by human agency and an institutional context (Bryman & Bell, 2015; Berger & Luckmann, 1967). For this study, this means that the way Region Uppsala actors describe, justify, and contest AI systems is itself the object of analysis, not a window onto independent organizational reality that lies behind those accounts. What actors say AI governance means, who they hold responsible for it, and how they frame the authority of algorithmic output are not incidental to the research but constitute the empirical material from which institutional dynamics are inferred.

Informed by Yin (2018) and Flyvbjerg (2006), this study utilizes an embedded single-case design: Region Uppsala is the case, and the three AI systems are the embedded units of analysis distributed across administrative, organizational, and clinical levels. A case study design is indicated when the phenomenon of interest cannot be meaningfully separated from its contextual environment and when how and why questions necessitate concrete empirical settings rather than controlled contexts (Yin, 2018). Region Uppsala was selected as a paradigmatic case (Flyvbjerg, 2006): not because it is representative of Swedish regions, but because it is one of the leading regions in the country in terms of AI adoption in the health care sector (AI Sweden, 2024). AI Sweden's Vårdkartan ('care map') is a publicly accessible national database that tracks AI

systems in use across Swedish healthcare regions; Region Uppsala's position at the top five of this register confirms it as the empirically advanced setting in which AI translation dynamics can currently be observed. Furthermore, the institutional context and the empirical saturation when studying the translation of AI governance templates in Region Uppsala will unfold the institutional dynamics that other region will likely face as they progress with their own AI digitalization journey. The empirical setting, the case selection, and the three AI systems are outlined in more detail in Section 3.2.

Abductive research is the selected approach for this study; it iterates between theoretical constructs and empirical data, with each informing and elaborating the other at various points in the research process (Van de Ven, 2007). This approach is suitable for this study because the research questions not only ask what translation mechanisms are in place but also why the same institutional environment produces divergent translation dynamics across AI systems and levels of organization, which cannot be solely answered on the strength of theory (deductively) or empirical data alone (inductively) iterate between theoretical constructs: institutional logics, translation mechanisms, decoupling, and empirical observations from the interviews, with insights from each informing and elaborating the other at various stages of the process.

In particular, the abductive approach is explicitly evidenced in the interview protocol, rather than asking respondents to talk about institutional logics in an abstract way, the interview questions were specifically designed to prompt narratives of daily practices, decision-making challenges, and governance practices, from which the relevant institutional dynamics were analytically inferred. The study is limited by its single embedded case and cannot claim statistical generalizability or causal inference. The abductive process can lead to post-facto rationalization (Van de Ven, 2007) which, while always a possibility, is here mitigated to the extent that the coding explicitly included data which did not fit with the developing theories as well as data that did, and the writing of memos was a constant feature of the analytical process. In this sense, the findings in this study were bounded to not assess how the AI technology works rather it documents how actors explain its governance.

3.2. Research Setting

3.2.1. Swedish Regional Governance and Institutional Pluralism

Region Uppsala fits the picture of Swedish regional governance in its pluralistic structure described in chapter 2: it is subject to professional, bureaucratic-legal, managerial, and political logics all at once. No one normative order can make the tensions between them resolve (Fredriksson & Pallas, 2016; Kommunallag, 2017:725). The logic of case selection is detailed in section 3.2.2 below.

3.2.2. Case Selection: Region Uppsala

The case study region was purposefully selected on theoretical grounds, as a paradigmatic case (Flyvbjerg, 2006): not as being representative or typical of other Swedish regions, but because it displays the institutional dynamics of interest in an unusually condensed form. As a constitutionally recognized region with healthcare, dental care, public transport, and regional development responsibilities for a population of approximately 380,000 people. Region Uppsala combines within a single organization both a university hospital that is one of the most authoritative sources of clinical expertise in the country, and a county council with administrative and political functions that answers directly to the elected regional assembly (Region Uppsala, 2025). All four logics are thus present and active within a single organizational entity. Region Uppsala is also nationally one of the leading regions in terms of AI adoption in healthcare (AI Sweden, 2024), which makes it empirically the most advanced and analytically the most generative setting in which AI translation dynamics can be currently observed in the Swedish regional public sector. The institutional dynamics that can be observed in this region are precisely those dynamics that all other regions in Sweden will encounter as they move forward with their own AI agendas, which makes the findings analytically generalizable beyond this single case (Flyvbjerg, 2006; Yin, 2018).

3.2.3. The AI Systems Under Study

This study focuses on three cases of AI adoption: administrative AI, clinical AI and pre-adoption AI, which differ in their domain of application, category of users and institutional pressures. They are also intentionally varied in the dimensions of technical readiness, stage of deployment and risk classification.

Their common factor is their institutional positioning: they all exist in the same organization and are shaped by the same plural logic configuration and travelling template. Inclusion of all three cases allows the study to capture how different translation dynamics can result from the same institutional setting, depending on where the AI is deployed in the organization, which stakeholder's authority is impacted, and who has control over the governance of the AI system. A summary of the three cases is presented in the following Table 3.

Table 3

Analytical Units: AI Systems Under Study in Region Uppsala

Unit	AI System	Domain	Translation Stage	Primary Logics Activated	Regulatory Status
1	*MS 365 Copilot*	Administrative	Enacted	Managerial; Bureaucratic-legal	General purpose; no high-risk designation under EU AI Act
2	*Clinical AI (Akademiska Sjukhuset)*	Clinical	Enacted	Professional; Bureaucratic-legal	High-risk (EU AI Act, Art. 6); enforcement 2026–2027
3	*Pre-Adoption AI* (Inera tool + Welfare unit potential AI)	Administrative / Social welfare	Prospective	Managerial; Bureaucratic-legal	Pending deployment; no current designation

Note. Translation stage distinguishes between enacted translation (system in active use) and prospective translation (system anticipated but not yet deployed). Primary logics refers to the institutional logics are most directly activated by each system; this is an analytical pre-classification grounded in organizational role, not a finding. Empirical analysis is presented in Chapter 4.

Unit one is Microsoft 365 Copilot, which presents an interesting site to examine governance ambiguity and tensions with GDPR data sovereignty (Microsoft, 2025), since the organization doesn't have an AI policy in place yet (Fahlstedt & Jacobsson, 2024; Selten & Klievink, 2024).

Unit two is clinical AI at Akademiska Sjukhuset. Unit two falls into the high-risk category according to article 14 of the EU AI Act. It will undergo a conformity assessment and mandatory for human oversight, as prescribed by the EU AI Act (European Commission, 2024). Unit two represents an interesting site for how professional, bureaucratic-legal, and algorithmic decision support logics interact in the high-stakes environment of a clinical setting.

Unit three is Pre-Adoption AI, a set of two cases, which are cases under the consideration of being implemented into use. Unit three consists of a proposed AI benefit calculator currently under development (Inera, 2026), and a proposed AI system for fraud detection in the welfare unit. Unit three represents what Strang & Meyer (1993) call prospective translation: this study is interested in how the logics act as a kind of interpretive filter to cases that have not yet been deployed for use. In this unit the innovation leader foregrounded managerial and political logic and the welfare unit participant foregrounded bureaucratic-legal logic.

3.3. Data Collection

The empirical material for this study primarily consisted of semi-structured interviews with Region Uppsala organizational actors involved in the governance, implementation, or routine use of AI-based systems. Semi-structured interviews were also chosen for practical reasons: they offered the simultaneous benefit of structured theme-relevance across interviews alongside the freedom to follow topics as they emerge during the interview (Bryman & Bell, 2015). As in the qualitative interview study of AI adoption in healthcare organizations in Sweden conducted by Petersson et al. (2022), an interview-based approach is especially apt for studying the way in which respondents themselves conceptualize and understand the role of governance instruments, since this can only be accessed through a first-order narrative rather than a direct response to a question. The theory of translation provided further rationale for this approach: change is theorized to occur through the editing function of actors in their organizational roles (Sahlin & Wedlin, 2008), and an interview provides the study with that first-order narrative of the way

actors in those roles talk about, give meaning to, legitimate, and organize in relation to, AI systems. Since this is an examination of the interpretive, sense-making aspect of the phenomenon and not its empirically documentable content, the empirical material was, for example, responses to questions about how they understood the EU AI Act and what that meant for their day-to-day work, rather than an analysis of the regulation document itself.

3.3.1. Sampling Strategy

The sampling strategy was employed as the method closely supporting the need to combine both purposeful and snowball sampling. In qualitative institutionalist research, the aim is not to be statistically representative, but rather to identify individuals who can speak to the phenomenon of interest in an analytically useful way (Reay & Hinings, 2009; Selten & Klievink, 2024). To ensure comprehensive feedback and broad perspectives collected, participants at different stages of translation for AI governance and processes were included in the sampling. More specifically, actors with experience in applied AI within their area of work, as well as actors in the prospective translation phase (see section 3.2.3.).

The applied set of criteria in the selection of sample / participants was two-fold: first, the level of AI- use, second, the geographical coverage within Region Uppsala. The field of action/expertise was concentrated around not only users, but also governance and implementation actors, as well as prospective users.

The process was initiated by a first discussion with a consulting company based in Uppsala, recommended through the Uppsala University Department of Business Studies. After a first discussion with a senior position contact at Region Uppsala, an initial list of potential participants was shared. The initial list was further refined applying two selection criteria: participant's availability within Region Uppsala and the level of relevance with regards to the use and type of AI.

The first round of interviews resulted in additional contacts having applied the snowball approach in obtaining direct recommendations of contacts relevant to a particular AI system (Noy, 2008). A directed approach was necessary to fill up a gap in role representation.

The sampling strategy was positional, following Fredriksson and Pallas (2016): the position someone holds at an organization influences which logic dominates their constructions of any given situation. The goal with sampling across positions (clinical, compliance, managerial, innovation, operational) is to make sure all four logics in the framework are present in the data. Only then does the study capturing tensions between them rather than only the logics that might have been selected.

3.3.2. Participants

Interviews were conducted with the following participants with ties to Region Uppsala. The following table displays all participants, the institutional role-based logic they represent, and general information about the interviews:

Table 4

Research Participants

#	Respondent (Role)	AI tools	Translation stage	Role-Based Logic Orientation	Meeting	Date	Duration
P1	Project Manager, Innovation	Inera tool	Prospective	Managerial + Professional	Online	16 Mar 2026	~35 min
		Skin cancer detection AI	Enacted				
P2	Senior Physician	Clinical AI	Enacted	Professional + Bureaucratic-legal	Online	17 Mar 2026	~45 min
P3	Operations Developer	Microsoft 365 Copilot	Enacted	Managerial + Bureaucratic-legal	Online	19 Mar 2026	~40 min
P4	Digitalization Strategist	Microsoft 365 Copilot	Enacted	Managerial + Bureaucratic-legal	Online	20 Mar 2026	~45 min
P5	Welfare Unit Leader	Welfare Unit AI	Prospective	Managerial-Bureaucratic-legal	Online	24 Mar 2026	~45 min
P6	Chief Digital Officer	Clinical AI	Enacted	Political + Managerial	Online	25 Mar 2026	~25 min
P7	Innovation Leader	No AI systems directly governed or owned	Strategic informant	Political – Managerial	Online	30 Mar 2026	~45-50 min
P8	Technical AI Specialist (1)	14 use cases (pipeline); governance & compliance framework (building)	Prospective	Managerial + Bureaucratic-legal	Online	30 Mar 2026	~45 min
P9	Operational informant - Welfare Unit	Welfare Unit AI	Prospective	Bureaucratic-legal + Professional	Asynchronous written response	26 Mar 2026	Written response
P10	Professor in Medical Sciences	Clinical AI	Enacted	Professional + Bureaucratic-legal	Online	27 Mar 2026	~50 min
P11	Unit Manager Medical AI	Clinical AI	Enacted	Managerial + Bureaucratic-legal	Online	1 Apr 2026	~50 min

#	Respondent (Role)	AI tools	Translation stage	Role-Based Logic Orientation	Meeting	Date	Duration
P12	Technical AI Specialist (2)	AI Transport tool	Prospective	Managerial + Bureaucratic-legal	Online	16 Apr 2026	~45 min

Note. For a few participants, the roles were generalized to reduce any threat of identification, since the precision of some jobs in a single site setting might lead to co-workers identifying colleagues despite the anonymized names. This was made clear to participants, who were provided the possibility of assessing their quoted text. P9 was included in this study as an anonymized written response forwarded by an intermediate since conducting direct interviews was not possible, in part because of the unit's security measures. The written response is an example of a method consistent with the rationales for Unit 3's purposive sampling and thus it was included as supplementary data within Unit 3's findings. The P6 interview ended prematurely due to a time limit, but the participant agreed to an additional session, which could not be scheduled during this study's time frame and the candidate availability.

3.3.3. Interview Structure and Conduct

The interviews were semi-structured and followed a thematic interview guide (see Appendix 8.1) derived from the analytical framework. Consistence with the abductive research strategy, questions were designed to ask respondents to describe specific practices, decisions and governance conditions rather than to talk about the institution in a general way that would then be subject to the analytical construction of competing logics and translation mechanisms. The interviews followed a thematic design with a predefined guide and open-ended questions whose order and depth were flexibly adjusted in response to themes that emerged, sometimes called semi-structured, but more accurately termed guided thematic interviewing (Selten & Klievink, 2024; Petersson et al., 2022). This design is suitable to an abductive strategy because it provides thematic consistency across the interviews while also leaving scope for novel themes to emerge (Van de Ven, 2007). The interview guide comprised five thematic blocks: (1) the respondent's role in relation to the AI system and how they had become involved; (2) how the AI system was conceived in terms of purpose, function and value to the organization; (3) perceived tensions or compatibilities between the AI system and professional practices, accountability mechanisms or organizational routines; (4) governance conditions surrounding the system, including oversight and accountability mechanisms; and (5) how the respondent understood the relationship between the AI system and the broader institutional and regulative expectations.

These blocks directly correspond to the research questions and analytical framework: blocks one and two deal with how actors construct AI systems from their institutional location, corresponding to Sub-question 1; blocks three and four seek to identify translation mechanisms and accountability gaps, corresponding to Sub-question 2; and block five relates the respondents' accounts to the traveling template stage of the framework, thereby enabling the analysis to determine whether the EU AI Act discourse is functioning as enacted governance or as theorization at the level of the organization. The study was conducted in English rather than Swedish, this represents researcher-imposed conditions rather than the preference of the respondents; more implications are discussed in the next section. Interviews lasted between 30-45 minutes and took place by video conference. With the permission of the respondent, interviews were digitally recorded and transcribed with OpenAI Whisper, which was run on a password-protected laptop to ensure that no audio information was transmitted to the internet, in accordance with the version of GDPR applying to research on public servants. Interview recordings were irreversibly deleted once the accuracy of the transcript had been checked.

3.4. Methodological Limitations and Reflexivity

Table 5

Methodological Limitations and How They Are Addressed

Limitation	Nature of risk	How addressed
Interviews were conducted in English	Specific Swedish institutional concepts for instance, (tjänstemannaansvar, Klarspråk, styrande dokument) may lose normative richness when translated to English.	When needed interviewees were asked to clarify and type in Swedish language the concepts/words (Into Zoom's chat). These words were retained in their original form within the research analysis.
Prospective translation case (Unit 3)	The Inera tool and welfare unit AI reflects anticipated rather than enacted practice; findings did not reflect on stabilization or routinization as outcome.	Prospective translation is an analytical framework introduced early on in (Section 3.2.3.). Findings are presented in chapter 4 without any claims about enacted outcomes.
First interview (not recorded)	Unlike the rest of the participants P1 data was gathered through handwritten	Extensive notes made during and immediately after the interview. P1 accounts used with

Limitation	Nature of risk	How addressed
	notes which may have resulted in a lack of granularity	caution; when possible, interpretations cross-checked against other informants.
No document analysis	Relying solely on interview data means formal governance framings (policies, procurement records, internal guidelines) cannot be compared with the practitioner accounts, the gap where likely decoupling would be most visible.	Acknowledged as a scope limitation. Future research combining interviews with document analysis would allow triangulation between prescribed and enacted governance.
No respondent validation	Interpretations remain my reconstruction of participant accounts rather than co-validated findings.	Mitigated by focusing on practical interview questions, systematic coding, and active search for counterevidence in the inductive phase. Timeline constraints of the master's thesis prevented a second validation round.
Single-case design	Findings cannot determine whether translation dynamics are specific to Region Uppsala's configuration or generalizable across Swedish regions.	Addressed through paradigmatic case logic (Flyvbjerg, 2006): findings are analytically rather than statistically transferable. Comparative regional research is identified as a future direction.
Theoretical sufficiency, not saturation	Interviews continued until sufficient empirical material was gathered per analytical unit, not until no new themes emerged, which is appropriate for an abductive design.	The paper followed theoretical sufficiency as a standard for an abductive, template-based coding design. The distinction is noted to avoid overstating data completeness.

Note. Limitations are presented in order of proximity to the data collection process. Researcher positionality is discussed in the paragraph below.

A further reflexive dimension concerns the researcher's role. Interviewing very senior respondents, such as the Chief Digital Officer and senior innovation position, carries the risk that respondents provide accounts inflected toward the institutionally preferred narrative, particularly that aligned with a managerial logic of modernization, rather than engaging critically with tensions and points of resistance. To mitigate this risk, the interview questions were located in concrete practices and specific decision situations rather than in organizational policies or strategic orientations, with the objective of eliciting practitioner narratives rather than performative scripts about the organization.

3.5. Data Analysis

Interview transcripts were analyzed using framework analysis (Ritchie & Spencer, 1994) in QualCoder v3.8.2, which supports both pre-defined deductive codes and iterative inductive coding consistent with the abductive approach. Analysis proceeded in two stages:

The first stage, deductive coding, was done by creating a coding template from the analytical framework consisting of four node sets (see table 6). The second stage, inductive coding, involved looking at the data for patterns not already covered by the pre-defined nodes. If such a pattern occurred in two or more interviews, a new inductive node was created and an analytic memo made on why the new node was analytically important. These memos constitute an audit trail for the dependability of the results (Lincoln & Guba, 1985). The full coding scheme can be seen in Table 6 below.

Table 6

Coding Framework: Deductive Template and Inductive Themes

Node Set	Codes	Operationalization (coding rule)	Key Sources
1. Institutional Logics	Professional logic	Coded when participant evaluates AI in terms of expertise/professional norms	Fredriksson & Pallas (2016); Thornton et al. (2012)
	Bureaucratic-legal logic	Legislation/accountability/liability	
	Managerial logic	Efficiency/productivity/organizational benefit	
	Political logic	Democratic values/public trust/political leadership	
Note: Multiple codes applied where logics coincide; dominant logic recorded in analytic memo.			
2. Translation Mechanisms	Reframing	Actor redefines purpose/meaning of AI to align with existing institutional values.	Sahlin & Wedlin (2008); Meyer & Rowan (1977)
	Layering	New control structures or procedures added alongside existing ones.	

Node Set	Codes	Operationalization (coding rule)	Key Sources
	Decoupling; [sub-code: Regulatory ceremonialism]	Where formal adoption deviates from actual practice. Regulatory ceremonialism: EU AI Act cited for legitimacy but with no visible effect on practice.	
3. Stabilization Outcomes	Substantive embedding;	AI integrated into daily decision-making routines.	Tolbert & Zucker (1996); Reay & Hinings (2009)
	Negotiated stabilization	AI in active use but authority/governance continuously contested across logics.	
	Ceremonial stabilization	AI formally adopted but loosely coupled from everyday practice.	
4. Translation Stage	Enacted translation	AI system operational; actors navigating institutional implications in ongoing practice.	Sahlin & Wedlin (2008); Strang & Meyer (1993)
	Prospective translation	Actors anticipating the institutional position of a governance technology that is not yet deployed for instance , (Unit 3).	
5. Inductive Themes	Responsibility gap; Governance structure absence; EU AI Act awareness; Self-generated governance norm; Support framing/substitution; Authority asymmetry by seniority; Cultural avoidance of AI governance; Performance metrics via AI; Prestige-driven prioritization; Value assessment (nytta); Professional identity boundary; End-user resistance	Emerged iteratively from data. New code created when pattern recurred across ≥2 interviews and was documented in an analytical memo. Codes capture dynamics not anticipated by the deductive framework.	Lincoln & Guba (1985); Van de Ven (2007)

Note. Node Sets 1- 4 constitute the deductive template obtained from the analytical framework in Chapter 2. Node Set 5 lists inductive themes that emerged from the data and were not anticipated by the framework. Codes in Sets 1–

4 may co-occur within a single passage; where they do, the dominant logic or mechanism is recorded in an analytic memo. The full code tree is reproduced in Appendix 8.3.

At every stage of the analysis, the process was iterative: after the first round of coding, the results were compared between the analytical units and then returned to the theoretical framework to see if the differences found could be explained within the existing theory or if it needed to be extended. This back-and-forth between empirical codes and theoretical categories is the abductive analysis described in Section 3.1 (Van de Ven, 2007). A table of how many times each code was applied across the interviews can be found in Appendix 8.2. , also as an audit trail.

3.5.1. Derivation of the three translation conditions from section 2.4

The three conditions introduced in section 2.4, "risk proximity," "logic dominance," and "governance ownership," were not in the deductive coding template (Table 6). The template had four node sets: institutional logics, translation mechanisms, stabilization outcomes, and translation stage. These three conditions, the "triad," emerged from an iterative abductive analysis process with the data. Three insights made this process of discovery clear. First, comparing across cases with node set one (logics) revealed that LD was more strongly shaped by location (site, not organization), in ways that the deductive template had picked up on as code distributions, but without explanation. Second, the nodes that were inductively generated in node set five were mostly about governance structure absence, reachability gap, role boundary as regulatory insulation, and corner-cutting risk in the research-clinical space: the inductive codes were mostly about the locus and clarity of accountability, and didn't cluster around any of the four logics, pointing towards an analytical category missing from the deductive template. Third, comparing the three units, the regulatory category of risk under the EU AI Act turned out to be institutionally more relevant than the translation literature had proposed. The triad is an attempt to consolidate those three discoveries into a unified theory. It is presented in its theoretical form in section 2.4 for analytical reasons, but its origins are in the analysis. This is exactly the kind of theoretical extension the abductive strategy of section 3.1 foresees.

3.6. Quality Criteria

As a qualitative and interpretive study, this analysis cannot be evaluated by the quantitative notions of reliability and validity. Instead, the study is evaluated by the four criteria for trustworthiness as proposed by Lincoln and Guba (1985). The criteria and how the study addresses them are outlined in Table 7 below.

Table 7

Trustworthiness Criteria and How They Are Addressed

Criterion	What it assesses	How this study addresses it
Credibility	Are interpretations grounded in the data and recognizable to participants?	Data collected from multiple waves of interviews throughout the organization; A combination of purposive and snowballing sampling used to achieve variation of the logic range; use of practice questions to minimize idealized responses; two-phase coding procedure deductive and inductive phase, in addition to search in the inductive phase also for counter-evidence; Swedish institutional concepts (tjänstemannaansvar, styrande dokument) retained in analysis.
Transferability	Can findings inform similar processes in other contexts?	Description of Region Uppsala's institutional configuration (section 3.2.1); justification of the Region as a paradigmatic case (Flyvbjerg, 2006) and thus establishing the analytic rather than statistical generalizability of the findings; explicit discussion of scope in which the findings' applicability to other Swedish regions in similar AI governance situations is addressed.
Dependability	Could a third-party trace and evaluate the analytical process?	Documenting the two-stage coding in section 3.5; coding decisions recorded in analytical memos written in QualCoder; pre-determined criteria for operationalization for each code in Table 6; code frequency audit trail in Appendix 8.2.
Confirmability	Are the findings data-driven rather than researcher bias?	Pre-defined coding template limits subjective interpretation: inductive phase actively seeks patterns that complicate rather than confirm the theoretical framework; reflexivity discussion in Section 3.4 addresses positional risks.

Note. Criteria follow Lincoln & Guba (1985). Elaboration of specific measures is provided in the sections referenced above.

3.7. Ethical Considerations

This study adheres to the general guidelines for qualitative research with human subjects. In accordance with Uppsala University's guidelines for ethical research conduct and the Swedish Research Council's codex for research in the humanities and social sciences (Vetenskapsrådet,

2017), the study followed the requirements of informed consent (including Participant 9), confidentiality, purpose limitation, and the principle of beneficence. Informed consent was obtained before the interview. The interviewees were informed about the purpose of the study, how the data would be used and stored and their right to withdraw from the study at any time. A written agreement was signed that stated the interviewees would be referred to by their job titles, not by names in any publications, that the audio files would be stored on a password-protected laptop and transcribed with a locally-installed software (OpenAI Whisper, offline mode) without being uploaded to any cloud storage, and that the recordings would be irreversibly deleted once the accuracy of the transcription had been checked. All these measures ensure the study is compliant with GDPR as it pertains to research studies with employees of Swedish public authorities. The participants are anonymized by title. Given the job titles and which organization, they work for, many of the respondents will be identifiable by their peers in Region Uppsala. This was explained to the interviewees who were also offered the chance to review and retract statements before submission. There weren't any vulnerable populations, deception and incentives involved. The interview questions were about professional, not personal, experiences. In line with the guidelines for generative AI from Uppsala University (Uppsala University, 2025), The AI tool used in this study is (Gemini, Google) was used to edit the language, summarize the researcher's own writing in certain cases where the word count was exceeded, format the document and do some structural revisions on a draft manuscript.

All intellectual content, theoretical reasoning, empirical analysis and conclusions are entirely owned by the researcher. No AI-generated text was submitted as original text, and all the referenced sources are genuine academic sources independently identified and verified by the researcher. The AI tool was not used for data analysis, coding or interpretation of interview material.

4. Empirical Analysis

This chapter examines the evidence gathered from the three analytical units. Each of the units is analyzed through three stages of analysis. First, presenting the empirical evidence (see table 8, 9 & 10). Second, the data is analyzed with the translation mechanisms (reframing, layering, and decoupling) and the resulting form of stabilization as an analytical lens. Third, the conditions that led to the specific translation mechanism used in the unit, (i.e., the levels of RP, LD, and GO discussed in Chapter 2), to showcase the factors that account for the variation in translation when the institutional settings are the same across the three units of analysis. In other words, the translation mechanism represents a primary analytical device, and the triad provides an explanation for the differences observed in the units. Finally, this section ends with a cross-unit synthesis which unfolds patterns and observations across the datasets.

4.1. Unit 1: Microsoft 365 Copilot is Administrative Enacted Translation

Microsoft 365 Copilot is the most used AI tool in Region Uppsala for administrative and coordination purposes. However, no participants described any region-wide policy for the use of the tool, a governance owner, or any training program for it. It is primarily guided by a managerial logic. Prompted by the need for digitalization and modernization, implementation happens outside the bureaucratic-legal boundaries while such tools would have to comply with in a regulatory framework like GDPR and the EU AI Act.

The following table structure displays snippets of the participants' accounts , the codes linked to these quotes, analytical observations that was recorded as analytical memos in QualCoder software, followed by the theoretical consequences. The same structure applied across the three units.

Table 8
Quote to Code Evidence Matrix: Unit 1 (Microsoft 365 Copilot)

Participant	Account Illustration	Code(s)	Analytical observation	Theoretical consequences
P4	*"We have no strategy, so no one decides. No one."*	NS4-GOV; NS4-RESP	No sign of organizational ownership over the Copilot tool or how individuals are using it from the corporate view, as a result, no one takes responsibility for a decision that no one makes.	Capacity-driven decoupling (Meyer & Rowan, 1977); ceremonial stabilization (Tolbert & Zucker, 1996)
P4	*"Everyone is using ChatGPT. So..."* [trailing off]	NS2-DC; NS3-CER	Formal mandate (use Copilot = safe environment) operationally displaced by a more capable tool; decoupling acknowledged, normalized, and left unresolved.	Ceremonial stabilization: formal adoption without substantive embedding (Tolbert & Zucker, 1996)
P4	*"If you have tensions in a room, you can get a really good analysis of what is actually happening with the people"*	NS1-MAN; NS4-GOV	Copilot extended into analysis of interpersonal dynamics outside the reframing as a writing tool ; EU AI Act could impose higher obligations on such use; no organizational structures that would enable members to identify and manage the expansion in the role and function of the tool.	Risk proximity gap: low institutional designation, rising actual use scope; governance ownership absent
P4	*"No one knows what they are meant for. I've tried several times to get in contact with them, but they don't want to really have any contact with us that is our experience." - "When we have tried to contact them, we get nothing back."* *"I'm hoping they are building something."*	NS3-CER; NS2-DC; NS1-POL; IND-REACH	Actively seeking AI governance support and when reached out to the AI specialized unit, there was no response despite the multiple attempts. This means the AI unit is formally there but as operation they are unreachable to other units. P4 describes governance based on hopes	Reachability gap; ceremonial stabilization at governance-body level (Meyer & Rowan, 1977); cross-referenced with P8 row 2 in Table 10 |

Participant	Account Illustration	Code(s)	Analytical observation	Theoretical consequences
P3	*"I just figure it out myself. No training, no guidance."*	NS4-GOV; IND-SELF	When it comes to tool usage the Individual governance took over the institutional governance by creating self-generated norms through processes such as (no personal data sharing, check the AI outputs) these processes replace the absence of organizational policy.	Adoption without embedding; self-generated norms as substitution for governance
P1	[Not aware of EU AI Act , extracted from taken notes; no recording]	NS4-TRIG; IND-COORD	The actor's role includes decisions regarding AI adoption across the organization unaware of EU AI Act as active regulatory frame for a coordination; governance coordination gap not frontline user gap.	Rationalized myth pattern (Meyer & Rowan, 1977): Act cited for legitimacy elsewhere, not as operational governance at the coordination level
P12	*"Copilot is not our responsibility, we are not going to be the one that teaches people how to use these types of AI safely. That's not in our job description."*	IND-SCOPE; NS4-RESP; NS2-DC; IND-REACH;	The person most knowledgeable about the EU AI Act in the organization also happens to be the one who is most opposed to adding previously existing AI tools (before this unit was founded) like Copilot into the unit's portfolio. The organization possesses the required expertise on the EU AI Act that could inform its members of what is permissible or mandatory to do. Yet this information is not shared.	Reachability gap strategic decoupling of compliance knowledge from actual use

Note. P1 account reconstructed from field notes; no audio recording thus it has been treated as paraphrased, not verbatim account. Codes used follow the structure from Table 6. For example: IND-SELF = self-generated governance norm; IND-SCOPE = scope ambiguity; IND-COORD = coordination-level governance gap; IND-REACH = reachability gap.

Table 8 shows how the seven accounts line up in an evidence chain. Three key conclusions arise from these accounts. First, P12 does not claim Copilot's responsibility within the AI specialized unit's mission and P4, the organization's top Copilot adopter in the dataset describes a context

where no one decides, together they unfold a GO void on all three levels at once. Second, while the participants' accounts about practical use of the AI seem to indicate that it was reframed and utilized as a writing tool, P4's quote about the tension in team meetings underscores that this reframing was the effort of an individual and that it was not an organizational design. P3 managed to procure an extended version of the software without any governance processes, this confirms that individual reframing changes as the use increases. Third, P1's account is analytically interesting because it indicates that the actor responsible for the decision regarding AI adoption was unaware of the relevant regulatory framework that would guide the AI tool's adoption. Overall, these seven accounts point to decoupling (Meyer & Rowan, 1977) being the principal translation mechanism of the unit, resulting in ceremonial stabilization. The three conditions listed below shed light on why such a combination of decoupling as a translation mechanism and a ceremonial stabilization as an outcome was noticed in the unit.

The explanation of the three conditions outlined in section 2.4 is why such institutional configuration of this type emerged in unit one. Firstly, the RP condition is low, as it is an institutionally low-risk condition designation under the EU AI ACT, thus not triggering the external institutional pressures that would have pushed them to be accountable. Secondly, the LD condition is managerial, as it is an instrumental and efficiency logic that leads to the adoption of the AI tool, without a bureaucratic and legal anchor that would have led to documenting the governance framework. Thirdly, the GO condition is absent: P4 and P12 have confirmed this from their different positions that no one in the organizational unit is responsible for the governance or ownership of the AI tool. This combination of the three conditions does not lead to a deliberate choice to decouple (in this case, to avoid accountability): they lead to a structural inevitability, as what has been observed here of ceremonial stabilization is not a consequence of actors intentionally avoiding their responsibilities, but a consequence of the institutional environment in which they do not find themselves compelled to assume responsibility for the AI tool.

4.2. Unit 2: Clinical AI at Akademiska Sjukhuset (Clinical Enacted Translation)

The EU AI Act plays a major role in causing intense institutional pressure in clinical AI at Akademiska Sjukhuset, since it operates in what is considered a high-risk environment under direct patient safety exposure (European Commission, 2024). The accounts from this unit's participants described a firm governance architecture that includes qualification processes, structured oversight mechanisms, and institutionally embedded accountability arrangements (Table 9). This unit represents an enacted translation, through its fully operational AI systems in use

Table 9

Quote to Code Evidence Matrix: Unit 2 (Clinical AI at Akademiska Sjukhuset)

Participant	Account Illustration	Code(s)	Analytical observations	Theoretical consequences
P6	*"So, we are working with an ISO standard 15288, system lifecycle management. Before we can go from prototyping into deploying a system in production, it needs to be qualified in this system catalog."*	NS2-LAY; IND-FORM; NS4-GOV (presence)	ISO-based governance architecture; qualification gates prior to deployment; system catalog, project portfolio, KPI-based quality reports: institutionalized formal layering in the dataset. Governance structure presence; contrast case for the entire dataset.	Substantive layering (Sahlin & Wedlin, 2008); negotiated stabilization trajectory (Reay & Hinings, 2009)

Participant	Account Illustration	Code(s)	Analytical observations	Theoretical consequences
P6	*"It is a little bit depending on the audience. In approaching clinicians... we do have a very high standard in terms of scientific evidence HTA* [Health Technology Assessment]*... For administrators* [the framing is] *productivity, efficiency."*	IND-AUD; NS2-RF; NS1-PRO	Audience dependent reframing; changing the justification and standard for evidence by changing the logic of the audience, i.e. using different justification depending on which role the target of communication occupies. For clinicians: HTA, patient safety, ethics. For administrators: efficiency. As a result, reframing here is a governance communication strategy rather than a tool of concealment.	Institutionalized reframing (Sahlin & Wedlin, 2008); professional logic embedded in governance design
P2	"*I am responsible"* [if the medical AI system commits a mistake]	NS1-PRO; NS4-RESP	Accountability clarity based on professional logic rather than the formal governance. Most clarity on accountability in the dataset; but this is a claim to be a product of professional logic, not a mapping of the accountability which exists within the system.	Professional logic as accountability anchor; contrast with administrative AI accountability vacuum (Unit 1)
P10	*"If it's very opaque, a black box, and the doctor cannot have any human oversight... then the doctor actually has less responsibility."*	IND-TRANSP; NS4-RESP; NS1-PRO	Link between Transparency and accountability: opacity controls the accountability distribution. Opaque models are the producer's responsibility; EU AI Act human oversight requirement is the governance mechanism maintaining doctor accountability. Most legally sophisticated accountability framework in the dataset.	Opacity-driven translation breakdown (section 5.2); EU AI Act as accountability governance mechanism (Laux et al., 2024)

Participant	Account Illustration	Code(s)	Analytical observations	Theoretical consequences
P11	*"We actually have 50 more systems waiting to be taken care of... which makes everything complicated."*	NS1-MAN; NS4-GOV	Governance at the infrastructure level overwhelmed by the spread of AI-embedded systems. The managerial logic for addressing the governance of such systems is a question of insufficient management capacity ; From the operation side, this is a manifestation of governance vacuum at the implementation level: the backlog is overwhelmed and no governance structure in place to absorb the load	Governance capacity gap; layered logic dominance: managerial logic at infrastructure layer, professional logic at clinical interface
P11	Three AI tools implemented and cancelled in 2018 (osteoporosis, thorax/lung, brain bleeding). *"We followed the normal process to take away*" no cross-unit learning distributed after withdrawal.	IND-CANC; NS3-WITH; NS4-GOV	There is no sedimented learning after de-institutionalization. The failed system withdrawn, reports on quality drafted, but without organizational memory to be circulated with other units about why it failed (including the AI specialized unit (Unit 3) that is currently establishing governance for this clinical field).	Extends Tolbert & Zucker (1996): de-institutionalization as stabilization outcome; organizational learning gap (section 4.4, and 5.2)
P1	Extracted from field notes : *Skin cancer is described as decision support tool; on the ground it replaces a referral route rather than assisting with one. When asked who bears responsibility for an error in the system, P1 could not identify an accountable actor.*	NS2-RF; IND-TRANSP; NS4-RESP	Reframing AI as assistive tool masks functional substitution of professional judgement. The actor responsible for adoption decisions cannot map accountability for errors which shows opacity-driven gap at the governance layer, not the clinical layer	Opacity-driven translation breakdown (Section 5.2); functional substitution reframing (Meyer & Rowan, 1977; Selten & Klievink, 2024)

Note. P10 (Professor of medical science, Uppsala University) not a regional employee, he is qualified as boundary informant; and attributed explicitly as contextual/comparative. P1 is a Unit 1 participant included here as a boundary informant due to direct involvement in Unit 2 adoption decisions for the skin cancer AI system P11 data, Unit Manager Medical AI. IND-AUD = audience-dependent reframing; IND-FORM = institutionalized formal layering; IND-CANC = cancellation as governance learning; IND-TRANSP = transparency-accountability link; NS3-WITH = withdrawn AI (de-institutionalization).

Table 9 shows the trace of evidence in the clinical AI, and the seven accounts support three findings. Layering is the relevant translation process: the ISO-based governance framework that P6 discusses in row 1 and the changing interpretation depending on the audience that P6 describes in row 2 are not ad hoc workarounds like in Unit 1. These are institutionalized arrangements that shape the way things are in this unit. Clarity of accountability exists in this unit, and it is not derived from the design in the formal layer. It is supported by professional logic and RP due to dealing directly with citizens' affairs. The fact that both P2 (I am responsible, row 3) and P10, who comes to the question from a completely different institutional angle, reach the same accountability insight (row 4) suggests that the link between transparency and accountability is logic-based, not policy-based.

Governance ownership exists at the layer of infrastructure, but it does not extend much beyond. The learning about cancellations for the 2018 AI tools described in P11's account (row 6) never reached the AI specialized unit that is currently building governance for that same clinical field. The significance of this is explored further in section 4.4. Overall, the evidence suggests that layering is the most relevant translation process, and negotiated stabilization is the most relevant outcome. Substantive embedding is underway for stroke and for mammography AI.

Before examining the triad, it is worth noting the finding in row 7, concerning P1's account of the AI for skin cancer, rather than acting as support, it seems to have functionally replaced a referral route: P1 (who is directly involved in adoption decisions) could not identify who would bear responsibility for an error. This cannot be attributed solely to an individual failure to map accountability. It suggests a governance layer gap arising out of the opacity, and its structural explanation falls under the triad conditions described further below (Meyer & Rowan, 1977; Selten & Klievink, 2024).

The triad condition explains why layering is used as translation mechanism and the reason behind ‘’opacity-driven accountability gap’’ in (P1-row7) account is structural and not

individual. the RP condition is high: Professional and bureaucratic-legal logics are simultaneously activated in this unit due to EU AI Act's strict requirements on clinical decision support that directly impact patient's safety (European Commission, 2024). When it comes to the LD conditions, it appears to be layered, the professional and bureaucratic-legal logics co-exist without competition while the first governs the interface and the latter governs the infrastructure. The ISO-based lifecycle model, steering committee, and system catalogue provide structured GO (third condition in the triad) for the clinical AI unlike unit one which lacks it entirely. The substantive layering in this unit is a result of the ownership configuration not just the dominant logic, without the GO and despite the dominant logic, the result most likely would be ceremonial stabilization.

4.3. Unit 3: Pre-Adoption AI is Prospective Translation

The third unit encompasses AI systems that have not yet been implemented: the AI specialized unit (P8, P12, P7 contributes with strategic framing), and the welfare related unit (P5, P9). Both are engaged in prospective translation, figuring out what the governance should be before any systems are online, and both highlight how institutional logics operate in the prospective phase (Sahlin & Wedlin, 2008).

Table 10

Quote to Code Evidence Matrix: Unit 3 (Pre-Adoption AI)

Participant	Account Illustration	Code(s)	Analytical observations	Theoretical consequences
P8 (AI specialized unit - AI Technical specialist (1))	"*We are doing everything as if we're going to be audited soon... governance is almost the main thing now."* [14 use cases in pipeline, none yet in production; lawyers, IT, and architects integrated from the start]	NS3-PRE; NS4-TRIG; IND-FORM	This is the only case observed in the dataset that the EU AI Act has not merely functioned as a legitimation reference but has also changed practice on the ground in a daily operation. Governance framework is under construction with three simultaneously ongoing processes for the framework design (platform design, delivery service, and governance of the tool itself). Compliance to the EU AI Act requirements is a	Pre-institutionalization (Tolbert & Zucker, 1996); institutionalized formal layering under construction (IND-FORM); it mirrors rationalized myth pattern in all other units (Meyer & Rowan, 1977)

Participant	Account Illustration	Code(s)	Analytical observations	Theoretical consequences
			reality, but is valid for projects deployed by the AI specialized unit only not the AI models previously deployed via other producers for the same organization	
P8	"*We don't officially have a mailbox or anything. We don't even have a page on the internet yet."* [Advisory-only authority; mandate still being defined; "*whether or not that is our job is kind of still up for definition"*]	IND-REACH; IND-SCOPE; NS3-CER	The AI specialized, created to coordinate regional AI was announced before operational infrastructure in place. No formal contact route, no published mandate, no enforcement authority. The symbol of governance and AI was created before the function which confirms P4's failed contact attempts as a structural gap, not a communication failure. (See table 8, P4 row)	Ceremonial stabilization at the governance-body level (Meyer & Rowan, 1977); reachability gap (IND-REACH); scope ambiguity as founding condition (IND-SCOPE)
P5 (Welfare Unit Senior Position)	"*We try to twist it around say: if we were to do something, what would you as a legal expert advise us to do?"* [AI flag alone is insufficient to initiate investigation; proportionality and GDPR cooperation as governance preconditions]	NS1-BL; NS4-RESP; IND-RESP	Bureaucratic-legal logic dominates as prospective governance design through legal proportionality, GDPR compliance, and jurisdictional thresholds embodied to the adoption rationale even before any system exists. The most important accountability safeguard , AI flag insufficient for action alone, exists only in P5's professional memory, without any documented policy.	Responsibility gap pre-empted by design (IND-RESP); professional memory as fragile governance substitute; bureaucratic-legal logic as the dominant pre-adoption frame (Fredriksson & Pallas, 2016)
P9 (Welfare unit Operational Informant)	[Written response] AI flag to be directed to "*specially designated officers*" with investigative background, not to line	IND-SEN; NS1-PRO; NS3-PRE	Seniority differential is confirmed as the same AI flag produces different governance outcomes depending on who receives it. Assigned specialist can	Authority asymmetry by expertise (IND-SEN); pre-institutionalization of governance design (NS3-PRE); connects

Participant	Account Illustration	Code(s)	Analytical observations	Theoretical consequences
	organization. "*The terminology may be of greater importance to legal professionals or managers*" operational staff indifferent to AI category label.		act; line organization without any relevant background cannot. This critical implementation design question who receives the output is unresolved in Region Uppsala's current planning.	to P2 and P11 authority asymmetry in Unit 2
P12 (AI specialized unit - AI Technical specialist (2))	"*People are working a lot in silos, we do our stuff and there's perhaps in many ways no consensus on how we should work with things."* - "*I hope that at least someone higher up from me should discuss with them. I hope*."	IND-REACH; NS2-DC; NS4-GOV	Silo structure confirmed from inside the AI specialized unit by P12 who knows that governance knowledge exists elsewhere but has no mechanism to access or share it. The conditional "*I hope*" framing signals that coordination is aspirational, not designed. The reachability gap is not a cultural problem, but it is a structural absence of horizontal governance mechanisms.	Reachability gap (IND-REACH); decoupling of governance knowledge across units (NS2-DC); structurally produced silo not incidental (Meyer & Rowan, 1977)

Note. P9 data collected via written response through an intermediate; treated as operational informant within the welfare unit, not full interview participant. IND-REACH = reachability gap; IND-SCOPE = mandate/scope ambiguity; IND-FORM = institutionalized formal layering under construction; IND-RESP = responsibility gap pre-empted by design; IND-SEN = seniority/expertise differential in AI governance.

Table 10 presents evidence for each of Unit 3's two sub-cases. There are three main themes across five accounts in this unit. The strongest pattern is the most obvious in this unit: prospective translation takes two forms. The AI specialized unit (P8, row 1) is currently designing its compliance processes with the EU AI Act before any such system is actually deployed, and the welfare unit is currently working through the legal requirements and proportionality tests that will need to be satisfied before it will be able to deploy any such system (P5, P9, rows 3 and 4). Both sub-cases are still within the habitualization stage (Tolbert and Zucker 1996), but they are getting there through different logics and are creating different governance designs as they do so.

A second theme concerns the lack of any operational system in one of these cases: the AI specialized unit (P8, row 2) was set up as a distinct AI unit before it even had a functioning office with mail, defined mandate and enforcement capabilities. This appeared not to be a gap in transitional phase but rather a founding condition. Therefore, the reachability gap that is observed in the Unit 1 account from P4 is not caused by coordination problems between units but is the outcome of the organizational design of the unit itself. This is confirmed via a source within the unit itself (P8).

A third pattern is a question of implementation design for both cases that is currently unresolved: to whom should AI outputs be sent? The written response of P9 (row 4) is clear that there are at least two options here, the specialist officer who is in the process of defining the scope of the new unit, or the line organization, and that this is not simply a technical question, but an organizational governance one. It also becomes evident that from the account of P12 (row 5), this cross-unit coordination is not yet defined, but is more aspirational than designed. This combination of accounts provides a description of a unit that is currently engaged in the creation of responsibility standards and governance norms ahead of any technology. This is, after all, the defining feature of pre-institutionalization; there is nothing yet that will stop the unit from heading in the intended direction, in line with its current trajectory.

The triad helps explaining why this unit is prospective, not enacted and both AI specialist unit and welfare AI system cases taking different forms within the same organization. For each sub-case, RP is only anticipated: there are no accountability systems yet that the unit must address. The unit must respond to avoid liability from such systems in the future. Since the RP is an anticipated force, this is why both units are taking deliberate, pre-adoption steps in governance design. LD is currently both bureaucratic-legal but is constructed differently in each sub-case. In the welfare AI case, it is legal proportionality considerations, while the AI specialized unit case takes the form of an EU AI Act compliance system design. This similarity means that both cases are operating in an anticipatory manner. Finally, while GO is internal, and concentrated within the AI specialized unit boundaries, it is currently absent externally. The unit will take up the role of the AI specialists and EU AI Act compliance lead but is currently not formally communicating this or integrating it structurally with the units that will be translating. This internal external split is what explains the split between what happens inside the AI specialized

unit and what occurs outside it, which both P12 and P4 point out from their respective vantage points. This is why the result of this unit is that it is still in pre-institutionalization, where responsibility design and governance norms are still being actively created. There are no systems on the ground to test the design. How this fits within the emerging cross-unit pattern are examined in the next section.

4.4. Cross-Unit Synthesis

The previous section's analysis unfolded three distinct translation mechanisms under four competing logics that resulted in different modes of stabilization within the same organization (see table 11). The illustration is followed by a synthesis of the reasons behind these patterns. Through discussing the three cross-unit patterns that are observed in all three data sets, then the discussion turns to the triad for explaining why the pluralistic institutional environment produces divergent translation dynamics.

Table 11

Cross-Unit Comparison: Translation Mechanisms, Stabilization Modes, and Triad Conditions

Unit	Translation mechanism	Stabilization mode	Logic dominance	Governance ownership	Key accountability gap
Unit 1 Copilot (admin, enacted)	Capacity-driven decoupling; individually enacted reframing	Ceremonial stabilization	Managerial (dominant); bureaucratic-legal absent	Absent at all levels; no unit claims responsibility	No formal mechanism; accountability vacuum; EU AI Act unknown to coordination actor (P1)
Unit 2 Clinical AI (clinical, enacted)	Institutionalized layering; audience- based reframing	Negotiated stabilization; sedimentation trajectory through (stroke AI, mammography AI)	Layered: professional at clinical interface; managerial at infrastructure layer	Structurally allocated (ISO model, steering committee, assigned governance position)	Opacity-driven gap (P1 skin cancer AI); de-institutionali-zation without sedimented learning (P11, 2018 tools)

Unit	Translation mechanism	Stabilization mode	Logic dominance	Governance ownership	Key accountability gap
Unit 3 Pre-adoption AI (prospective)	Prospective translation: bureaucratic-legal pre-conditions (welfare unit); EU AI Act compliance construction (AI specialized unit)	Pre-institutionalization (habitualization stage; no forward trajectory established)	Bureaucratic-legal (both sub-cases)	Internally concentrated (AI specialized unit); externally absent (no mailbox, no mandate communicated)	Reachability gap: governance knowledge exists but does not reach other units; critical design question unresolved (who receives AI output)

Note. Translation mechanisms, stabilization modes, and triad conditions are drawn from the unit's analysis in sections 4.1 to 4.3. GO is the most analytically distinguishing condition across units (explained in this section). The three decoupling types (capacity-driven, opacity-driven, strategic) are discussed further in the cross-unit synthesis below.

There are three patterns that appear in all three units sufficiently consistently to support assertions at the dataset level.

First, the responsibility gap is pervasive throughout (Laux et al., 2024): no participants report any formal architecture designed to ensure that AI accountability is clear. Where accountability appears in the dataset, it emerges either from professional culture or from risk proximity; no participants describe any formal mechanism for ensuring that the right person has responsibility for any given AI activity.

Second, the organizational compliance with the EU AI Act exhibits structural decoupling. In this case, compliance knowledge is widespread in the organization, but the effects of that knowledge are limited to the AI specialized unit. No participants mentioned any mechanism for sharing compliance knowledge within other units already utilizing technologies covered by the EU AI Act (Laux et al., 2024; Meyer & Rowan, 1977).

Third, is the reachability gap: governance know-how is present within the organization yet not disseminated among the various work units due to the silo culture. The second structural gap is

different in its analytical character: an organizational learning gap is where experience does not travel across time. In other words, no accounts in the dataset described that the organization has mechanisms to learn from its own experience: past failures are not shared across units or time (Sahlin & Wedlin, 2008). The organizational learning gap thus compounds the reachability gap: the silo failure spans both space and time.

With these three cross-unit patterns above, it is logical step to return to the coded material and address the research question: why did the same institutional context result in different translation mechanisms in the three units?

Of the three conditions outlined in section 2.4, the only one that provides sufficient explanation for the different outcomes from the translation across units, why, in some cases, translation resulted in ceremonial compliance rather than substantive outcomes in the way that is discussed in the previous sections is GO. The codes that capture the allocation or non-allocation of accountability for an AI system (NS4-GOV, NS4-RESP, IND-REACH, IND-ROLE, IND-CORN) are the most common in the data across the widest number of participants.

The other two conditions describe inheritances: RP is determined by the EU AI Act and by the location of the technology in the work process, and LD is set by the institutional history at each site (Fredriksson & Pallas, 2016). GO is likely the only condition within the triad that is constructed by the organization and evidence in the data indicates that the variation in this construction is what accounts for the most variation in the translation outcomes observed in these three units. In this respect, the data aligns with the broader accountability gap literature (Bovens, 2007; Yuan & Chen, 2025): The responsibility gap within the dataset is not inherent to AI, but to how the organization has configured GO. All three of the patterns described in the following can be read as manifestations of how such configuration shapes translation.

Comparing NS1-PRO (Professional logic) activation profiles across the units, it was evident that the NS1-PRO concentration of Unit 2 (clinical AI) paralleled the strongest governing outcomes; by contrast, the prevalence of NS1-MAN (managerial logic) in Unit 1 (Microsoft 365 Copilot) paralleled the clearest manifestations of decoupling. This co-occurrence suggests that LD operates as a conditioning variable.

A second comparison of NS4-GOV (governance absence) reveals that absence is widespread and unstructured in Unit 1; it is thus structurally managed with partial compensation in Unit 2; and, despite the lack of an operational system, it is pre-empted in Unit 3 (pre-adoption AI). This is suggestive of a second variable: GO.

Finally, RP emerges from a comparison of the actors whose accountability framing is most explicit in the data. Here, the actors with explicit accountability framing (P2, P10, P11) are also actors with direct patient safety exposure; whereas the actors whose accountability accounts are most diffuse or absent (P1, P4, P12) are actors who lack this proximity to risk. The robustness of these three patterns to an outlier case is notable: Unit 3 (pre-adoption AI) is a unit that is small and under-resourced and currently in a prospective stage; yet it produces what is likely the most deliberate governance design in the case set; this pattern aligns with the prediction that bureaucratic–legal LD and explicit GO should pre-empt the gaps in accountability provision that have emerged so prominently in other parts of this study. Therefore, the triad is not an initial deductive hypothesis; it is an abductive inference based on comparing the coded patterns found in each unit and stress-testing them against the outlier case that seems most likely to falsify them.

The opacity mechanism is best articulated by P10, the only respondent to develop this concept into an accountability principle: When an AI system is transparent the doctor remains responsible for its output because the output can be evaluated; when it is opaque the responsibility transfers to the producer because it is impossible for human beings to exercise oversight. The data does not uniformly support this principle, it rather conforms to the principle, because in unit 1 (Copilot), opacity is largely inconsequential given the low RP and the ability of the output to be measured against the domain expertise of the user; in Unit 2 (clinical AI), opacity shapes accountability along the lines P10 specifies and, in unit 3 (pre-adoption), opacity is anticipation-based in P9's signal-specificity concern, an issue that is a form of functional opacity at the level of the signal in operation. Thus, in this discussion, P10 is credited with formulating the idea while the cross-unit data is viewed as supporting, not as a uniformity.

The cross-unit synthesis further reveals that decoupling cannot be described as a unitary phenomenon. Three types are evident in the data, which are important to distinguish are presented in table 12

Table 12

Three types of decoupling derived from the empirics : Types: Mechanisms and Cases

Type	Mechanism	Empirical case
Capacity-driven decoupling	The misalignment of form and substance in the adoption of Copilot can be understood because of organizational immaturity and lack of ownership, rather than a deliberate choice to loosely couple	Copilot (Unit 1)
Strategic decoupling	Formal compliance exists internally in the AI specialized unit while remaining inaccessible to other units	AI specialized unit (Unit 3)
Opacity-driven decoupling	The actors are not choosing to decouple governance from practice. In P10's case, the system's opacity forecloses the conscious editing that any coupling between governance and practice would require	Clinical AI / P10 (Unit 2)

The differentiation of decoupling types is reported in this section as empirical observation, as for the theoretical implication it is addressed in the next chapter (section 5.2)

5. Discussion

This chapter links the empirical findings presented in Chapter 4 with the theoretical framework in Chapter 2. In addition, it answers the research questions, discusses theoretical contributions, and practical implications.

5.1. Answering the research questions

The first sub-question examined the process of navigating institutional logics. Overall, the accounts across all three units point to similar responses, highlighting that actors' navigation of these logics is dependent on positional location, their proximity to risk, and the particular institutional logic primarily invoked in a specific location. In each of the three units, a singular institutional logic provides a central point to frame around as the main logic that dominates the other competing demands. To illustrate this, Table 11 details the configuration. This indicates that the professional institutional logic dominates at the interface of the clinical care delivery. The administrative unit lacks the anchor of bureaucratic-legal institutional logic, thus allowing managerial institutional logic to take over. Finally, bureaucratic-legal logic governs pre-adoption sub-cases. The political logic presented in the conceptual framework in chapter 2, however, it didn't emerge in the data as dominant governance pressure at any of the three units, which is a sign that no elected officials took the lead on adopting AI governance and this can be considered as a form of operating through strategic silence not active framing. This finding is discussed further below in this section. The welfare unit represents a partial exception, where P5 pre-empts governance gaps through a self-generated proportionality norm constructed before any system is live, albeit this norm was carried and not institutionalized at the organizational level. Organizations as organizations do not navigate, their actors do.

The second sub-question focused on identifying which mechanisms of translation could be identified in the units. All three identified mechanisms of editing occur in the dataset, but to varying degrees and to varying levels. Reframing occurs in every unit, but to different levels: on an individual level, to maintain the professional boundaries in the Copilot unit, and as an organizational-level mechanism, to hide a practice that in effect is a substitution of one practice for another in the skin cancer AI unit. Layering is present in clinical units, facilitated by their

established institutionalized governance structures. Decoupling is present in the two enacted units, however in two different forms: at the system level and capacity-driven in Copilot, and at the institutional level and driven by strategy in the AI specialized unit, in line with the two types described in section 4.4. What connects all these patterns, and which distinguishes them from typical accounts of organizational change, is that they are not indicative of a deliberate organizational strategy. These instances of translating AI occur as a direct institutional outcome of a) where in the organizational structure the AI systems were adopted, b) which institutional logic primarily dominated that site, and c) whether governance ownership system existed in any form. Thus, the short answer to the second sub-question is that mechanisms of translation vary because the context in which they occur, i.e. the conditions, vary, rather than the actors making different choices.

The main research question asked how AI systems are translated and institutionalized in a Swedish regional public agency under a condition of institutional pluralism. To provide the short answer: it is unevenly, and without any overall coordination. None of the systems in the data are at a stage of sedimentation, which is reached once a new practice becomes taken-for-granted, and the organization retains it when the individual actors who initiated it are gone (Tolbert & Zucker, 1996). In the clinical units, the translation process is on the way towards being substantively embedded. However, this is happening at a domain-level, and not as an organizational level practice. Uneven translation is therefore not a sign that there has been any failure with AI implementation. This is a direct, structural outcome of the situation of institutional pluralism: it is determined by how risk is framed and which logic is activated at the location of adoption, and whether there is any actor who is positioned of GO (Fredriksson & Pallas, 2016; Reay & Hinings, 2009).

This unevenness is the output of an accountability configuration that is not institutionally neutral. The ambiguity in which AI system is the responsibility of whom gives discretion to the actors situated above the translation layer. Senior management is enabled to adopt and roll out AI with no concomitant accountability commitments; the lack of governance facilitates political dodging where no elected official is formally called on to take a stance. The responsibility instead lies with the individual practitioners, who are most distant from those responsible for the original decision that led to this arrangement. The gap in accountability is therefore not merely an

organizational problem. Rather, it is productive of those situated above the translation layer, and it cannot be solved with a governance document on its own.

5.2. Theoretical contributions

This study was intended to contribute in four ways to the current literature on implementation of AI systems. The first contribution relates to the framework of institutional logics. This study extends Fredriksson and Pallas (2016)'s model by showing that logic activation varies by domain within the same organization. The triad RP, LD and GO advances the institutional logics framework as follows: to a mid-range model that moves from what logics can be observed in an institutionally plural environment to under which conditions one logic will dominate the translation at a particular site. There are alternative explanations that cannot hold water in the light of the data. A resource-based account couldn't explain why the welfare unit, which is the smallest and the least resourced sub-case, has the most deliberate governance design in the entire sample. Leadership accounts couldn't explain why P2, P10, and P11 converge on identical accountability frames without any interaction between them. The triad provides an account of both as a function of institutional positioning, as opposed to organizational capacity or individual agency.

The second contribution relates to the idea of AI implementation. This study challenges the diffusion model that there is no uniform reception of the EU AI Act governance template; in the AI specialized unit it acts as a standard of compliance that changes daily practice, but in administrative and clinical units it acts as rationalized myth, used for legitimacy but does not change practice (Meyer & Rowan, 1977). The significance of theoretical finding is not because translation happens , which is well established, but the fact that the template is simultaneously a standard of compliance and a rationalized myth in the same organization. This advances the translation perspective (Czarniawska & Joerges, 1996; Sahlin & Wedlin, 2008) by showing the importance of the unit of analysis, and that diffusion and translation are not competing explanations of the same thing, but rather explanations of what is happening in different organizational sites at the same time.

Third, this study contributes to the theory of translation for AI systems. Translation theory was developed to make sense of how ideas are mobilized as text or narrative, objects that actors can

read, discuss, and consciously edit (Czarniawska & Joerges, 1996; Sahlin & Wedlin, 2008). A computer algorithm is not such an object: the logics behind it are automated and its operation can be opaque, and thus, an actor may be editing something that they are unaware of. Thus, this study contributes to a fourth category of translation modes, termed as *opacity-driven translation breakdown*, where the unavailability of the object for reading precludes conscious editing, and creates a forced decoupling of the object. This contribution is two-fold: first, it adds the editing mode specific to algorithmic governance templates, which were not accommodated in the translation mechanisms, second, it revises the understanding of what decoupling is. Within the confines of an opaque algorithm, the distinction between the formal structure and the informal does not exist to the same extent, and so, the decoupling in such context is not a choice by the management, but rather, a forced decision by the object. This theoretical refinement is relevant to future research outside Region Uppsala because algorithmic opacity is an inherent attribute of AI, rather than a circumstantial feature, and thus, this study's theoretical extension to the assumption of a readable object can be generalized across cases with different types of AI systems.

In addition, the fourth boundary associated with Tolbert and Zucker's (1996) institutionalization model which suggest that organizational practice follow forward trajectory until sedimentation. The identified organizational learning gap that stems for the clear evidence of medical imaging AI systems that were withdrawn in 2018 whose institutional memory has not been passed to the AI specialized unit is currently building governance for the same domain. This means that de-institutionalization can happen without leaving sedimented learnings behind. This finding suggests that Tolbert and Zucker's model requires an extension to account for de-institutionalization as stabilization outcome rather than treating it as a deviation from the forward path. Therefore, this study contributes to the boundary condition for translation theory as well as refinement of institutionalization theory under pluralistic governance.

5.3. Implications for Practice

The findings have three implications for practice: First, the problem of who is responsible cannot be solved simply by forming a governance unit. It requires that unit to be accessible and its mandate communicated and formalized with clear accountability arrangements rather than being

carried in an actor's professional history. The most important accountability measure is in the professional history of one actor in the welfare unit. A governance responsibility that is individually carried is one step from disappearing.

The second important implication of this study is the need for matching governance attention with AI use and deployment, rather than simply the degree of risk associated with it. Copilot is not classified as high-risk according to the EU AI Act, however, it is the most commonly used AI system across the organization: P4 states that *"everyone, every manager in primary care, which is like hundreds of people in our organization"* might be required to use it, and P12 confirms that colleagues are using a multitude of AI systems (Copilot, ChatGPT, and Claude) in different contexts *"without even having anyone in the organization responsible".* This means that tools which have the broadest deployment, may have the broadest diffusion of responsibility, despite low levels of risk associated with each decision.

Third, the organization already has the governance it requires, it is just not shared. The AI governance unit has created an authentic EU AI Act compliance structure. Akademiska Sjukhuset has a mature ISO-based clinical AI governance model. What is needed most is cross-unit coordination, not more policy. However, a more worrying implication of this case is that the lack of AI governance documented here is not a function of poor oversight, lack of expertise or under-investment, but rather, a result of the very logic of this pluralist institutional environment. The governance failure here is structurally driven by the plurality of the institutional logics: when four different types of institutional logics operate within the same environment, each of them creates a distinct and legitimate accountability frame of their own. Consequently, without a mechanism that coordinates and reconciles these different frames into a single cohesive system, the gap is not simply one waiting to be filled, but rather, an inevitable consequence of institutional pluralism. Those practitioners attempting to improve AI governance should expect that this is not achieved through more governance, but instead, through active disruption of these institutional logics.

6. Conclusion

This study examined the translation and institutionalization of AI in a Swedish regional public agency operating in institutional pluralism. The empirical site is Region Uppsala, a constitutional and plural organization that is subject to multiple logics (professional, bureaucratic-legal, managerial, and political) and the analyzed units are three different AI systems, covering administrative, clinical, and pre-adoption AI. The main argument is the variation between different translations is not noise around implementation. It is the implementation. The argument explains the variation through three conditions: risk proximity, logic dominance, and governance ownership. The same governance template is, therefore, translated and institutionalized differently depending on where it lands within the organization.

The main finding is that in an institutionally plural environment, institutionalization is asymmetrical by design, and this explains how the same institutional backdrop will lead to different forms of stabilization. In Region Uppsala Copilot gets ceremonial stabilization, clinical AI gets negotiated stabilization by layering, and the governance of AI specialized unit gets split into internalized substance while the unit is external ceremonial stabilization. This is not failed implementation, but rather a consequence of the different logics meeting the same template in different organizational sites. Where professional logic is activated by risk proximity, actors negotiate governance without formal mandates. Where managerial logic dominates without a bureaucratic-legal anchor, AI is adopted without accountability. Finally, where governance ownership is assigned, but the organizational prerequisites for the implementation of the role is not established, the systems will comply locally in the organization, but the overall governance structure will not.

The findings of the study make four theoretical contributions. The first contribution is the introduction of the triad as a mid-range model. Building on Fredriksson and Pallas (2016), it moves beyond identifying the existing logics to which conditions determine which logic governs the translation. The second contribution is a reframing of AI implementation as translation rather than as diffusion. This conceptual move shifts the analytical eye from an organization using AI to an organization translating and editing AI and the result could be actual accountability systems, or only appearance of it. The third contribution identifies a limitation in the current

literature around translation that has not yet been addressed. The current theory is developed based on objects that can be read and consciously edited by actors. When the object is opaque such as algorithms, it is difficult to be edited by actors consciously, which results involuntary decoupling. The fourth theoretical contribution is an extension to Tolbert and Zucker's institutionalization model. The findings reveal that de-institutionalization could happen without sedimented learnings, which is the case of the imaging AI tools withdrawn in 2018 that left no institutional memory reaching the AI specialized unit which currently building governance for the same domain.

The common pattern across the above contributions is that the responsibility gap around AI implementation is not a problem that can be solved by regulation. The EU AI Act is already known in the regional public agency. However, the reachability and learning gaps are preventing governance knowledge about AI from spreading to the different AI systems. Therefore, the problem cannot be eliminated by implementing regulations. The solution to this is a deliberate governance design build by the organization. The region needs a formalized AI governance function that is given a mandate and has communication channels that are easy to find for any unit in the organization. The issue is not that there is a lack of governance around the AI implementation. The issue is that the governance of AI does not reach the different levels where translation occurs.

All four contributions carry a practical insight. To begin with, the responsibility gap is not a technical problem that awaits a regulatory solution. There is indeed an EU AI Act, and it is known. The gap continues to exist because the reachability and learning gaps prevent knowledge about governance from reaching the domains in which translation actually happens. Regulation alone will never solve the problem. When formalized AI governance functions with communicated mandates and easily accessible contact points are combined as a deliberate organizational design. The real problem is the absence of a governance that reaches to the translation level.

6.1. Future research and limitations

The study was conducted in one organization and at one moment, and without the benefit of documentary or observational data. An open question is whether the patterns that are

documented here (the pervasive responsibility gap, the two-speed adoption of the EU AI Act and the silo structure) are particular to Region Uppsala or general to Swedish regional agencies. It would require a comparative study across two or more Swedish regions to address the question. If the triad holds, we would expect more substantive AI governance when the risk proximity in an organization is higher in a domain. Similarly, the same pattern will hold for the assignment of governance ownership ; an AI governance role that is assigned to an organization will lead to a more substantive AI governance. Finally, the triad could provide an analytically generative framework for research to test the model in more detail. The model is not proposed as a causal law, but as a set of conditions that can be empirically tested.

This study established that AI governance in public organization is first and foremost an institutional not technical affair and without structural support it defaults to ceremony.

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8. Appendices

8.1. Interview Guide

The following is the thematic structure of the semi-structured interview questions; the structure served as orientation tool that is consistent with the abductive research approach. Several elements were adjusted to match each participant's role and the concerned AI system relevant to their unit, for instance (wording, depth and order). Furthermore, the following blocks connects directly to the research sub-questions and analytical framework in Chapter 3.

Block 1 — Role and Involvement

- → Could you briefly describe your role and how it relates to AI at Region Uppsala?
- → How did you first become involved with the specific AI system(s) we will be discussing?
- → Who else in the organization is involved with this system from your perspective?

Block 2 — How the AI System is Understood

- → How would you describe the purpose of this AI system to a colleague who has not used it?
- → What value does it provide to you, to your team, or to the organization?
- → Has the way you think about this system changed since it was first introduced?
- → Are there aspects of what the system does that you find difficult to explain or account for?

Block 3 — Tensions with Existing Practices

- → Have there been any moments where the AI system produced a result that conflicted with your own professional judgment? How did you handle that?
- → Has the introduction of the system changed how decisions are documented or justified?
- → Are there colleagues who have reacted differently to the system more skeptically or more enthusiastically? What explains the difference?
- → Have you ever had to push back on how the system is being used, or been asked to use it in a way you were not comfortable with?

Block 4 — Governance, Oversight, and Accountability

- → Who, in your understanding, is responsible if this AI system produces an incorrect result that feeds into a decision?
- → Is there a formal process for oversight of this system for example, regular review, performance monitoring, or designated oversight roles?
- → Are you aware of any internal guidance policies, agreements, or guidelines that specifically address this AI system?
- → Have you tried to get in contact with any governance body or expert for advice about this system? What was that experience?

Block 5 — Regulatory and Institutional Expectations

- → Are you familiar with the EU AI Act, and if so, how does it relate to your work with this system?
- → Do you feel that Region Uppsala is prepared for the governance obligations the Act sets out?
- → In your view, what is the most important governance gap in how AI is currently managed in this organization?
- → Is there anything about your unit's relationship to AI that we have not covered that you think I should understand?

Note: Participant P9 (Operational informant at welfare unit) hasn't been interviewed, instead six interview question were submitted by the unit superior and the participant responded asynchronous in writing, The

questions covered areas such as AI practices in other prior state experience, the discretion when AI flags a case, AI errors and accountability frameworks; the effect of the Sekretesslagen reform, the learnt lesson from other AI deployment in different prior unit experience, in addition to what has been underestimated in the current AI planning for their unit.

8.2. The code Frequency

Table 13

Code Frequency Audit Trail Across Participants (P1–P12)

Code	Label	P1	P2	P3	P4	P5	P9	P6	P7	P8	P10	P11	P12	Total
Node Set 1 — Institutional Logics														
NS1-PRO	Professional logic	1	5	2	–	5	1	6	2	–	11	4	1	**38**
NS1-BL	Bureaucratic-legal logic	1	5	11	2	6	3	2	3	5	6	7	7	**58**
NS1-MAN	Managerial logic	4	2	2	8	9	1	6	4	6	–	12	9	**63**
NS1-POL	Political logic	–	–	2	3	4	–	1	12	2	1	1	–	**26**
(NS1-HYB)	*(Logic hybridity — analytic memo notation)*	–	1	–	2	1	–	1	1	–	–	–	1	7
Node Set 2 — Translation Mechanisms														
NS2-RF	Reframing	1	2	2	–	9	1	6	4	1	2	10	3	**41**
NS2-LAY	Layering	1	1	1	–	4	2	7	–	4	3	7	3	**33**
NS2-DC	Decoupling	4	1	5	10	2	1	1	3	7	1	1	6	**42**
NS2-RC	↳ Sub-code: Regulatory ceremonial decoupling	1	4	–	2	1	–	–	–	1	–	–	3	12
Node Set 3 — Stabilization Outcomes														
NS3-NEG	Negotiated stabilization	1	3	2	1	3	–	5	1	–	–	4	1	**21**
NS3-CER	Ceremonial stabilization	–	–	2	5	–	–	1	–	1	1	–	2	**12**
NS3-SED	Sedimentation (trajectory toward substantive embedding)	–	1	–	–	–	–	1	–	–	–	3	–	**5**
(NS3-PRE)	(Pre-institutionalization — operational sub-code)	1	1	–	–	4	5	–	–	9	2	2	12	36
Node Set 4 — Translation Stage (This Node is used only as a meta-data as well as enacted translation)														
NS4-PROS	Prospective translation	–	–	–	–	6	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	**6**

Code	Label	P1	P2	P3	P4	P5	P9	P6	P7	P8	P10	P11	P12	Total
Node Set 5 — Inductive Themes (standalone QualCoder nodes)														
NS4-GOV	Governance structure absence	5	4	4	14	–	3	9	8	11	11	11	11	**91**
NS4-RESP	Responsibility gap	2	1	1	5	–	1	2	1	7	3	3	5	**31**
NS4-TRIG	EU AI Act awareness	1	1	1	1	1	1	–	–	4	2	2	2	**16**
IND-SELF	Self-generated governance norm	–	–	4	3	–	1	–	2	–	–	–	–	**10**
IND-AUTH	Authority asymmetry by seniority	–	2	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	1	2	–	**5**
IND-CULT	Cultural avoidance of AI governance	–	–	–	2	–	–	–	1	–	–	–	–	**3**
IND-SURV	Professional identity boundary	–	1	1	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	**2**
IND-PRES	Prestige-driven prioritization	–	–	–	2	–	–	–	2	–	1	–	–	**5**
IND-ROLE	Role boundary as regulatory insulation	–	–	3	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	1	–	**4**
IND-HOPE	Hope-based governance	–	–	–	3	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	**3**
IND-COG	Risk in cognitive dependency	–	–	–	2	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	**2**
IND-DOWN	Downstream consequence blindness	2	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	2	–	**4**
IND-REACH	Reachability gap	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	2	1	1	4	**8**
IND-SCOPE	Scope ambiguity	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	8	–	–	2	**10**
IND-FRAG	Fragmented decision making	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	3	4	–	–	2	**9**
IND-REACT	Reactive governance culture	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	6	–	–	–	–	**6**
IND-DATA	Data governance as foundational gap	–	–	–	–	–	1	–	4	3	4	3	–	**15**
IND-LEAD	Leadership deficit in digitalization	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	2	–	–	–	–	**2**
IND-FORM	Institutionalized formal layering	–	–	–	–	–	–	2	–	2	–	–	–	**4**
IND-CANC	Cancellation as governance learning	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	4	–	**4**
IND-MON	Operational monitoring as governance practice	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	3	–	**3**
IND-SEN	Seniority differential in AI literacy	–	–	–	–	5	4	–	–	–	–	–	–	**9**
IND-CAT	AI category management	–	–	–	–	2	1	–	–	–	–	–	–	**3**

Code	Label	P1	P2	P3	P4	P5	P9	P6	P7	P8	P10	P11	P12	Total
IND-RESP	Responsibility gap obstructed by design	–	–	–	–	4	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	**4**
IND-SIG	Signal specificity problem	–	–	–	–	–	2	–	–	–	–	–	–	**2**
IND-UNDER	Governance underestimation pattern	–	–	–	–	–	1	–	–	–	–	–	–	**1**
IND-CROSS	Cross-institutional translation complexity	–	–	–	–	1	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	**1**
IND-CORN	Corner-cutting risk	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	6	1	–	**7**
IND-TRANSP	Transparency-accountability link	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	2	–	–	**2**
IND-IP	IP and commercialization governance gap	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	2	–	–	**2**
IND-TRSF	AI framed as a colleague	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	2	–	**2**
IND-SILO	Silo working	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	4	**4**
IND-BOUND	Boundary spanning gap	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	1	**1**
IND-QUANT	Non-quantifiable risks	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	–	2	**2**

Note: *the counts are exported directly from QualCoder v3.8.2 into excel sheet then imported into this file, and it's randomly verified against the row export file for different participants to ensure the accuracy. . NS2-RC (Regulatory ceremonial decoupling)is a subcode as mentioned in table 3; . NS3-SED (Sedimentation)is highlighted in the passages where practice was assessed as reaching or approaching taken-for-granted stage which is consistent with the substantive embedding described previously in the analytical framework; . NS4-ENACT, Enacted translation and NS4-PROS Prospective translation are not coded as a passage rather a meta data and it was treated as case-attribute level. Several inductive themes named in Table 3, such as, 'Support framing/substitution', 'Value assessment (nytta) , and 'End-user resistance' became a part of few existing deductive nodes such as (NS2-RF and NS1-MAN)) rather than as standalone inductive nodes; they appear in the code tree (Appendix C) with the parent code indicated*

8.3. QualCoder Code Tree

The following figure shows the complete code tree structure that is applied in QualCoder V3.8.2 across the interviews. The tree contains four deductive template branches that originated from the analytical framework in Chapter 2, and one inductive theme branch that grew progressively as empirical material required conceptual extension beyond the pre-defined categories.

Figure 2: QualCoder Code Tree — AI Governance Study, Region Uppsala

Deductive template categories (logics · mechanisms · outcomes · stage) and inductive themes as applied across INT01–INT04. Source: QualCoder 3.8.2, March 2026.

